

DEGRADING ISIS – FROM DEFENSE TO OFFENSE

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Confronting the ISIS Threat

By THE EDITORIAL BOARD

President Obama said on Sunday that now is the time “to start going on some offense” against the Islamic State in Iraq and Syria, or ISIS, the Sunni extremist group that is overrunning northern Iraq and has a stronghold in Syria. That would be a serious escalation of the American role there.

He will need to explain to the nation with specificity how airstrikes against ISIS in Syria fit into a broader strategy; how they could be successful; how they might be done without benefiting Syria’s dictator, Bashar al-Assad, who is under attack by ISIS and other Sunni opposition forces; and how the United States can avoid entanglement in another military morass if it moves more aggressively into this theater.

Until ISIS emerged as a regional threat, the Obama administration argued it had no legal standing to become militarily involved in Syria. American forces began airstrikes in August against ISIS fighters in Iraq after units of the Iraqi Army collapsed and extremists began persecuting minority groups, attacking the Mosul Dam and threatening Americans in Erbil. There seemed to be legal grounds for airstrikes because Iraq asked for assistance and Americans were at risk. From the beginning, Mr. Obama has pledged that ground troops would not be involved.

Administration officials now say Mr. Obama has authority to take action even across the porous Iraq-Syria border if there is intelligence identifying ISIS fighters in Syria involved in the beheadings of two American journalists or if requested to do so by the Iraqi government to protect its border.

Their assertion, however, does not resolve the question of the need for congressional authorization for military attacks in Syria. Lawmakers, facing re-election in November, seem divided on the need for a vote, although they will at least have to approve new financing for the mission. Mr. Obama himself has been ambiguous, saying in one breath, “I’m confident that I have the authorization that I need to protect the American people” and, in another, that Congress needs “to have buy-in” on the issue.

While most of the focus has been on military action, the administration’s strategy is broader, and those other elements — political, economic and diplomatic — are as important. On Monday, the Iraqis approved a new, more inclusive government, which the Americans pressed for and is essential to undercutting ISIS’s grip on disaffected Sunnis. There are plans for a new provincial force that would bring Sunnis and Shiite militias into Iraqi security structure and plans to train and equip moderate Syrian rebels so they can capitalize on airstrikes in Syria.

The Obama administration is also trying to marshal an international coalition to fight ISIS, but success is far from guaranteed. On Sunday, Arab League foreign ministers agreed to take necessary measures to confront ISIS, but they made no specific commitments. On Monday, a meeting between Defense Secretary Chuck Hagel and Turkish officials did not result in any firm announcement.

There are many ways for countries to make contributions, including shutting down channels for ISIS financing, closing Turkey's border to ISIS fighters and weapons, urging Sunni tribes to work with the Shiite-led government in Baghdad, and providing intelligence to coalition members. But there are also many impediments and complications to getting disparate countries to work together, including Turkey's fear that ISIS, in retaliation, might kill 49 Turkish diplomats held by the militants.

Mr. Obama has called ISIS a serious threat and has said, "we have the capacity to deal with it." On Wednesday, he plans to give a speech about the issue. His challenge will be to persuade American and foreign listeners that he has an effective strategy to eliminate the threat.

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Obama to Speak on Strategy for 'Destroying' ISIS

By MARK LANDLER

WASHINGTON — President Obama will address the nation at 9 p.m. on Wednesday about how the United States plans to confront the threat from the Sunni extremist group, the Islamic State in Iraq and Syria.

In the speech, Mr. Obama will lay out a strategy for “degrading and ultimately destroying the terrorist group,” Josh Earnest, the White House press secretary, said in a statement.

The decision to schedule the address during prime time, from the state floor of the White House, underscores the gravity of the challenge from ISIS. It comes after an intense internal debate and diplomatic outreach to assemble a coalition to target ISIS.

Mr. Obama plans to meet with Republican and Democratic leaders of the House and Senate on Tuesday afternoon to build Congressional support for his action. On Monday evening, he and Vice President Joseph R. Biden Jr. invited nine foreign-policy experts to a three-hour dinner to preview his policy.

Mr. Obama, who was joined by Vice President Joseph R. Biden Jr., Secretary of State John Kerry, and other senior officials, looked “forward to engaging with this group and hearing their views on a range of national security and foreign policy issues,” the White House said in a statement.

But the purpose of the gathering seemed more for Mr. Obama to give his guests, several of whom are fixtures on television talk shows and op-ed pages, a preview of the plan for confronting the threat from the Sunni militant group the Islamic State in Iraq and Syria, a plan he has promised to reveal on Wednesday.

On Tuesday afternoon, the president will meet at the White House with Republican and Democratic leaders of the House and Senate, hoping to build congressional support for what administration officials warn could be a prolonged military campaign against ISIS.

The White House has said little about the details of Mr. Obama’s speech, which officials said was still being written Monday. But the carefully orchestrated buildup underscored the stakes for a president who was harshly criticized for confessing two weeks ago that he did not have a strategy for dealing with the militants in Syria.

The guest list, which included national security advisers to three former presidents from both parties, represented a full range of views about the risks of returning to Iraq.

Two of the guests — Stephen J. Hadley and Richard N. Haass — worked for the George W. Bush administration and have direct experience with the Iraq war and its chaotic aftermath. Mr. Hadley was national security adviser to Mr. Bush in 2007, when his administration undertook the troop surge in Iraq. Mr. Haass was director of policy planning at the State Department during preparations for the war in 2003.

Now the president of the Council on Foreign Relations, Mr. Haass recently criticized what he

views as Mr. Obama's overstretched foreign policy. "There is a growing mismatch between the rhetoric and the policy," he said. "The world has proved to be a far more demanding place than it looked to this White House a few years ago."

Two of the other guests, Samuel R. Berger and Zbigniew Brzezinski, advised Democratic presidents during foreign crises: Mr. Berger, while Bill Clinton was weighing airstrikes in Bosnia and Kosovo; Mr. Brzezinski, while Jimmy Carter was dealing with the Iran hostage crisis.

Mr. Obama also invited three veterans of his administration who were involved in counterterrorism policy: Tom Donilon, a former national security adviser; Michele Flournoy, the former No. 2 official at the Pentagon; and Michael J. Morell, a former deputy C.I.A. director.

Rounding out the table were Strobe Talbott, the president of the Brookings Institution, who served in Mr. Clinton's State Department, and Jane Harman, a former Democratic congresswoman from California who now runs the Woodrow Wilson Center. Ms. Harman criticized Mr. Obama last week for not making a public statement immediately after the beheading of the second American journalist, Steven J. Sotloff, by an ISIS militant. "I think it's time for him to say more and do more," she said on CNN.

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Turkey Is Courted by U.S. to Help Fight ISIS

By HELENE COOPER

ANKARA, Turkey — The Obama administration on Monday began the work of trying to determine exactly what roles the members of its fledgling coalition of countries to fight the Islamic State in Iraq and Syria will play, with Defense Secretary Chuck Hagel huddled with the leaders of the one country the administration has called “absolutely indispensable” to the fight: Turkey.

But after hours of meetings here, there were no announcements of what the government of President Recep Tayyip Erdogan might do. In fact, Turkish officials meeting with Mr. Hagel eschewed the news conferences that usually accompany high-level visits from American officials.

Rather, Turkey’s foreign minister, Mevlut Cavusoglu, warned on the state-run Anatolia news agency that weapons sent by Western countries to fight ISIS could end up in the hands of the Kurdistan Workers’ Party, or P.K.K., which Ankara considers a terrorist group.

“We have expressed our concerns,” Mr. Cavusoglu said. “It may not be possible to control where these weapons will go.”

Turkish officials raised concern about a host of issues surrounding the coalition, including the safety of 49 Turkish diplomats who have been taken hostage by ISIS, and whether the growing international effort to arm Kurdish fighters in Iraq against ISIS could embolden Kurdish militants in Turkey who have been seeking autonomy for the country’s largely Kurdish southeast. Turkish Kurds with the P.K.K. have fought with Kurdish pesh merga fighters in northern Iraq against ISIS. Turkey is also grappling with an influx of more than 800,000 Syrian refugees — the largest Syrian refugee population after Lebanon’s.

Speaking to reporters after meeting with Mr. Erdogan on Monday, Mr. Hagel said that Turkish officials had expressed to him their concern about the P.K.K. But, he added, “They didn’t indicate to me in any way that they saw the P.K.K. as a more significant threat than ISIL,” using an alternative acronym for ISIS.

The Obama administration wants Turkey to crack down on the flow of foreign fighters who have used the country as a transit point to Syria to join militant groups fighting there. The United States also wants to be able to use Turkish military bases to begin operations, including airstrikes, on ISIS targets in Iraq and Syria if President Obama decides to attack inside Syria.

“By geography, Turkey is going to be absolutely indispensable to the ongoing fight against ISIS,” a senior defense official said, speaking on condition of anonymity. “Because of just where they sit, the access we currently already have militarily and the cooperation we have militarily.”

Mr. Erdogan, at the NATO summit meeting in Wales last week, met with Mr. Obama and said Turkey would become the only majority Muslim country so far to join what Mr. Hagel termed a “core coalition” of 10 countries fighting ISIS. Mr. Obama said after the meeting

that he would welcome Turkey's participation in his coalition.

But Turkey has several times balked at allowing the American military to use its bases for operations in the region — most famously in Iraq in 2003. Mr. Erdogan himself has a complicated relationship with Mr. Obama. The two initially formed a close personal relationship during Mr. Obama's first term, and Turkey was the first majority Muslim country that the American president visited after taking office.

But the relationship soured over differences on Egypt and Syria, and deteriorated even more when Mr. Erdogan suggested that a conspiracy involving the United States was behind a corruption investigation by Turkish prosecutors that targeted him and his inner circle.

Mr. Hagel said the tensions between the United States and Turkey should not get in the way of joining in the fight against ISIS. "Yes, we've had our ups and downs in the relationship, but what's interesting is it has never broken," Mr. Hagel said.

"Now," he added, "we have a situation in the world today that presents a clear and new set of very real threats." Mr. Hagel said the United States expected that Turkey "will be involved in all of our efforts, as articulated by the president, to build a coalition to deal with ISIL."

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The Saudis Can Crush ISIS

By NAWAF OBAID and SAUD AL-SARHAN

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RIYADH, Saudi Arabia — As ISIS continues to grow, many commentators have been pointing to Saudi Arabia as the source of the group, and most assume that the United States is the only force that can stop it. Both of these assertions are incorrect.

Saudi Arabia is not the source of ISIS, it's the group's primary target.

ISIS' core objective is to restore the caliphate (an Islamic empire led by a supreme leader), and because Saudi Arabia is the epicenter of Islam and the custodian of the Two Holy Mosques in Mecca and Medina, ISIS' road to the caliphate lies through the kingdom and its monarchy. Indeed, ISIS has even launched a campaign against Saudi Arabia, called qadimun, or "we are coming" to take over the country. Saudi Arabia has put the group on its list of terrorist sponsors, declared that funding ISIS is a crime with severe penalties, and arrested ISIS supporters and operatives over the past several months. Continue reading the main story

ISIS emerged not from Saudi Arabia but from postwar Iraq and the remnants of Saddam Hussein's senior officer corps and their local support networks in Iraq and Syria. This has enabled ISIS to capture large swathes of land in these two countries and seize valuable economic, financial and energy assets, thus becoming financially self-sufficient. Now they are after Saudi Arabia's riches.

The kingdom's enormous oil fields and monetary wealth have always been coveted by Al Qaeda, as they are now by ISIS. Of course, with typical hypocrisy, while Al Qaeda and ISIS covet the kingdom's riches, they also despise the way it has modernized in order to capitalize on that wealth — seeing it as having strayed from proper Islamic practices.

Why, then, do so many people believe Saudi Arabia is behind ISIS?

At the root of the claim that Saudi Arabia created ISIS is the belief that both entities practice a version of Islam called Salafism (erroneously known in the West as Wahhabism). While it is true that the kingdom espouses Salafism, ISIS' claim that it is Salafi has no basis. Salafism is based on the word salaf, or "the ancestors," referring to the way Islam was practiced by Prophet Muhammad's early followers in the religion's first three generations.

The Salafists believe that Islam should be practiced according to the dictates of these ancestors. Different interpretations of these dictates have occurred over time, leading to four schools of jurisprudence in Sunni Islam. The founders of these schools were Abu Hanifah, Malik, Al Shafi'i, and Ibn Hanbal.

ISIS follows an ideology that is a continuation of a crude sect known as the Kharijites, or the ones that "deviated" from the Muslim community during the reign of the fourth Caliph Ali (whom they assassinated). The Kharijites believed that whoever disagreed with them should be murdered as infidels (takfir), rationalized mass killings against civilians, including

women and children (isti'rad), and practiced an extreme form of inquisition to test their opponent's faith (imtihan).

These concepts make ISIS' ideology the absolute opposite of Saudi Salafism. The version of Salafism applied in the kingdom's courts and religious institutions was formulated by one of the four leading Muslim jurists, the ninth-century scholar Ahmad ibn Hanbal. Hanbali law stands firmly against sedition, shedding of blood, and forcible conversion.

One of Ibn Hanbal's best known sayings typifies current Saudi theology: "Glory to God; shedding blood! Shedding blood! I do not consent nor do I command it; to observe patience in our situation is better than sedition that causes the shedding of blood."

ISIS poses a unique threat: It is a bloodthirsty movement that can find disaffected young men and women and recruit them from among the world's 1.3 billion Sunnis. It does not face the numerical constraints of groups like Hezbollah or countries like Iran, whose ideologies only appeal to the smaller Shiite community. With such enormous growth potential, ISIS must be defeated now.

Saudi Arabia is the only authority in the region with the power and legitimacy to bring ISIS down. Having effectively eradicated Al Qaeda in the kingdom, the Saudi government, with its experience fighting terrorism, is uniquely positioned to deal with ISIS, which is, after all, an Al Qaeda-aligned organization. The kingdom has built up an impressive counterterrorism program and its counterterrorism strategies are considered some of the most sophisticated and effective in the world.

More importantly, the Saudi leadership has a unique form of religious credibility and legitimacy, which will make it far more effective than other governments at delegitimizing ISIS' monstrous terrorist ideology. The message sent to the Muslim and Arab worlds as Saudi Arabia takes on ISIS is radically different from — and much preferable to — the message sent if the United States does so, especially given America's recent disastrous record in the Middle East.

When ISIS first appeared in Syria in 2011, Saudi Arabia tried to galvanize support for the moderate Syrian opposition against the murderous regime of Bashar al-Assad. But the world failed to listen.

Now, as King Abdullah of Saudi Arabia recently pointed out, ISIS is not only a threat to the Middle East, but to Europe and America. We call on the international community to form a solid coalition with Saudi Arabia to roll back ISIS' military advances while at the same time supporting the kingdom's ever increasing campaign to delegitimize ISIS in the eyes of the wider Sunni world, in order to ultimately destroy it.

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PART 1

You Can't Understand ISIS If You Don't Know the History of Wahhabism in Saudi Arabia

Alastair Crooke, Fmr. MI-6 agent; Author, 'Resistance: The Essence of Islamic Revolution'

This article is Part I of Alastair Crooke's historical analysis of the roots of ISIS and its impact on the future of the Middle East.

BEIRUT -- The dramatic arrival of Da'ish (ISIS) on the stage of Iraq has shocked many in the West. Many have been perplexed -- and horrified -- by its violence and its evident magnetism for Sunni youth. But more than this, they find Saudi Arabia's ambivalence in the face of this manifestation both troubling and inexplicable, wondering, "Don't the Saudis understand that ISIS threatens them, too?"

It appears -- even now -- that Saudi Arabia's ruling elite is divided. Some applaud that ISIS is fighting Iranian Shiite "fire" with Sunni "fire"; that a new Sunni state is taking shape at the very heart of what they regard as a historical Sunni patrimony; and they are drawn by Da'ish's strict Salafist ideology.

Other Saudis are more fearful, and recall the history of the revolt against Abd-al Aziz by the Wahhabist Ikhwan (Disclaimer: this Ikhwan has nothing to do with the Muslim Brotherhood Ikhwan -- please note, all further references hereafter are to the Wahhabist Ikhwan, and not to the Muslim Brotherhood Ikhwan), but which nearly imploded Wahhabism and the al-Saud in the late 1920s.

Many Saudis are deeply disturbed by the radical doctrines of Da'ish (ISIS) -- and are beginning to question some aspects of Saudi Arabia's direction and discourse.

THE SAUDI DUALITY

Saudi Arabia's internal discord and tensions over ISIS can only be understood by grasping the inherent (and persisting) duality that lies at the core of the Kingdom's doctrinal makeup and its historical origins.

One dominant strand to the Saudi identity pertains directly to Muhammad ibn 'Abd al-Wahhab (the founder of Wahhabism), and the use to which his radical, exclusionist puritanism was put by Ibn Saud. (The latter was then no more than a minor leader -- amongst many -- of continually sparring and raiding Bedouin tribes in the baking and desperately poor deserts of the Nejd.)

The second strand to this perplexing duality, relates precisely to King Abd-al Aziz's subsequent shift towards statehood in the 1920s: his curbing of Ikhwani violence (in order to have diplomatic standing as a nation-state with Britain and America); his institutionalization of the original Wahhabist impulse -- and the subsequent seizing of the opportunely surging petrodollar spigot in the 1970s, to channel the volatile Ikhwani current

away from home towards export -- by diffusing a cultural revolution, rather than violent revolution throughout the Muslim world.

But this "cultural revolution" was no docile reformism. It was a revolution based on Abd al-Wahhab's Jacobin-like hatred for the putrescence and deviationism that he perceived all about him -- hence his call to purge Islam of all its heresies and idolatries.

MUSLIM IMPOSTORS

The American author and journalist, Steven Coll, has written how this austere and censorious disciple of the 14th century scholar Ibn Taymiyyah, Abd al-Wahhab, despised "the decorous, arty, tobacco smoking, hashish imbibing, drum pounding Egyptian and Ottoman nobility who travelled across Arabia to pray at Mecca."

In Abd al-Wahhab's view, these were not Muslims; they were imposters masquerading as Muslims. Nor, indeed, did he find the behavior of local Bedouin Arabs much better. They aggravated Abd al-Wahhab by their honoring of saints, by their erecting of tombstones, and their "superstition" (e.g. revering graves or places that were deemed particularly imbued with the divine).

All this behavior, Abd al-Wahhab denounced as bida -- forbidden by God.

Like Taymiyyah before him, Abd al-Wahhab believed that the period of the Prophet Muhammad's stay in Medina was the ideal of Muslim society (the "best of times"), to which all Muslims should aspire to emulate (this, essentially, is Salafism).

Taymiyyah had declared war on Shi'ism, Sufism and Greek philosophy. He spoke out, too against visiting the grave of the prophet and the celebration of his birthday, declaring that all such behavior represented mere imitation of the Christian worship of Jesus as God (i.e. idolatry). Abd al-Wahhab assimilated all this earlier teaching, stating that "any doubt or hesitation" on the part of a believer in respect to his or her acknowledging this particular interpretation of Islam should "deprive a man of immunity of his property and his life."

One of the main tenets of Abd al-Wahhab's doctrine has become the key idea of takfir. Under the takfiri doctrine, Abd al-Wahhab and his followers could deem fellow Muslims infidels should they engage in activities that in any way could be said to encroach on the sovereignty of the absolute Authority (that is, the King). Abd al-Wahhab denounced all Muslims who honored the dead, saints, or angels. He held that such sentiments detracted from the complete subservience one must feel towards God, and only God. Wahhabi Islam thus bans any prayer to saints and dead loved ones, pilgrimages to tombs and special mosques, religious festivals celebrating saints, the honoring of the Muslim Prophet Muhammad's birthday, and even prohibits the use of gravestones when burying the dead.

"Those who would not conform to this view should be killed, their wives and daughters violated, and their possessions confiscated, he wrote. "

Abd al-Wahhab demanded conformity -- a conformity that was to be demonstrated in physical and tangible ways. He argued that all Muslims must individually pledge their allegiance to a single Muslim leader (a Caliph, if there were one). Those who would not conform to this view should be killed, their wives and daughters violated, and their possessions confiscated, he wrote. The list of apostates meriting death included the Shiite, Sufis and other Muslim denominations, whom Abd al-Wahhab did not consider to be Muslim at all.

There is nothing here that separates Wahhabism from ISIS. The rift would emerge only later: from the subsequent institutionalization of Muhammad ibn 'Abd al-Wahhab's doctrine of "One Ruler, One Authority, One Mosque" -- these three pillars being taken respectively to refer to the Saudi king, the absolute authority of official Wahhabism, and its control of "the word" (i.e. the mosque).

It is this rift -- the ISIS denial of these three pillars on which the whole of Sunni authority presently rests -- makes ISIS, which in all other respects conforms to Wahhabism, a deep threat to Saudi Arabia.

BRIEF HISTORY 1741- 1818

Abd al-Wahhab's advocacy of these ultra radical views inevitably led to his expulsion from his own town -- and in 1741, after some wanderings, he found refuge under the protection of Ibn Saud and his tribe. What Ibn Saud perceived in Abd al-Wahhab's novel teaching was the means to overturn Arab tradition and convention. It was a path to seizing power.

"Their strategy -- like that of ISIS today -- was to bring the peoples whom they conquered into submission. They aimed to instill fear. "

Ibn Saud's clan, seizing on Abd al-Wahhab's doctrine, now could do what they always did, which was raiding neighboring villages and robbing them of their possessions. Only now they were doing it not within the ambit of Arab tradition, but rather under the banner of jihad. Ibn Saud and Abd al-Wahhab also reintroduced the idea of martyrdom in the name of jihad, as it granted those martyred immediate entry into paradise.

In the beginning, they conquered a few local communities and imposed their rule over them. (The conquered inhabitants were given a limited choice: conversion to Wahhabism or death.) By 1790, the Alliance controlled most of the Arabian Peninsula and repeatedly raided Medina, Syria and Iraq.

Their strategy -- like that of ISIS today -- was to bring the peoples whom they conquered into submission. They aimed to instill fear. In 1801, the Allies attacked the Holy City of Karbala in Iraq. They massacred thousands of Shiites, including women and children. Many Shiite shrines were destroyed, including the shrine of Imam Hussein, the murdered grandson of Prophet Muhammad.

A British official, Lieutenant Francis Warden, observing the situation at the time, wrote: "They pillaged the whole of it [Karbala], and plundered the Tomb of Hussein... slaying in the course of the day, with circumstances of peculiar cruelty, above five thousand of the inhabitants ..."

Osman Ibn Bishr Najdi, the historian of the first Saudi state, wrote that Ibn Saud committed a massacre in Karbala in 1801. He proudly documented that massacre saying, "we took Karbala and slaughtered and took its people (as slaves), then praise be to Allah, Lord of the Worlds, and we do not apologize for that and say: 'And to the unbelievers: the same treatment.'"

In 1803, Abdul Aziz then entered the Holy City of Mecca, which surrendered under the impact of terror and panic (the same fate was to befall Medina, too). Abd al-Wahhab's followers demolished historical monuments and all the tombs and shrines in their midst. By the end, they had destroyed centuries of Islamic architecture near the Grand Mosque.

But in November of 1803, a Shiite assassin killed King Abdul Aziz (taking revenge for the massacre at Karbala). His son, Saud bin Abd al Aziz, succeeded him and continued the conquest of Arabia. Ottoman rulers, however, could no longer just sit back and watch as their empire was devoured piece by piece. In 1812, the Ottoman army, composed of Egyptians, pushed the Alliance out from Medina, Jeddah and Mecca. In 1814, Saud bin Abd al Aziz died of fever. His unfortunate son Abdullah bin Saud, however, was taken by the Ottomans to Istanbul, where he was gruesomely executed (a visitor to Istanbul reported seeing him having been humiliated in the streets of Istanbul for three days, then hanged and beheaded, his severed head fired from a canon, and his heart cut out and impaled on his body).

In 1815, Wahhabi forces were crushed by the Egyptians (acting on the Ottoman's behalf) in a decisive battle. In 1818, the Ottomans captured and destroyed the Wahhabi capital of Dariyah. The first Saudi state was no more. The few remaining Wahhabis withdrew into the desert to regroup, and there they remained, quiescent for most of the 19th century.

HISTORY RETURNS WITH ISIS

It is not hard to understand how the founding of the Islamic State by ISIS in contemporary Iraq might resonate amongst those who recall this history. Indeed, the ethos of 18th century Wahhabism did not just wither in Nejd, but it roared back into life when the Ottoman Empire collapsed amongst the chaos of World War I.

The Al Saud -- in this 20th century renaissance -- were led by the laconic and politically astute Abd-al Aziz, who, on uniting the fractious Bedouin tribes, launched the Saudi "Ikhwan" in the spirit of Abd-al Wahhab's and Ibn Saud's earlier fighting proselytisers.

The Ikhwan was a reincarnation of the early, fierce, semi-independent vanguard movement of committed armed Wahhabist "moralists" who almost had succeeded in seizing Arabia by the early 1800s. In the same manner as earlier, the Ikhwan again succeeded in capturing Mecca, Medina and Jeddah between 1914 and 1926. Abd-al Aziz, however, began to feel his wider interests to be threatened by the revolutionary "Jacobinism" exhibited by the Ikhwan. The Ikhwan revolted -- leading to a civil war that lasted until the 1930s, when the King had them put down: he machine-gunned them.

For this king, (Abd-al Aziz), the simple verities of previous decades were eroding. Oil was being discovered in the peninsular. Britain and America were courting Abd-al Aziz, but still were inclined to support Sharif Husain as the only legitimate ruler of Arabia. The Saudis needed to develop a more sophisticated diplomatic posture.

So Wahhabism was forcefully changed from a movement of revolutionary jihad and theological takfiri purification, to a movement of conservative social, political, theological, and religious da'wa (Islamic call) and to justifying the institution that upholds loyalty to the royal Saudi family and the King's absolute power.

OIL WEALTH SPREAD WAHHABISM

With the advent of the oil bonanza -- as the French scholar, Giles Kepel writes, Saudi goals were to "reach out and spread Wahhabism across the Muslim world ... to "Wahhabise" Islam, thereby reducing the "multitude of voices within the religion" to a "single creed" -- a movement which would transcend national divisions. Billions of dollars were -- and continue to be -- invested in this manifestation of soft power.

It was this heady mix of billion dollar soft power projection -- and the Saudi willingness to manage Sunni Islam both to further America's interests, as it concomitantly embedded Wahhabism educationally, socially and culturally throughout the lands of Islam -- that brought into being a western policy dependency on Saudi Arabia, a dependency that has endured since Abd-al Aziz's meeting with Roosevelt on a U.S. warship (returning the president from the Yalta Conference) until today.

Westerners looked at the Kingdom and their gaze was taken by the wealth; by the apparent modernization; by the professed leadership of the Islamic world. They chose to presume that the Kingdom was bending to the imperatives of modern life -- and that the management of Sunni Islam would bend the Kingdom, too, to modern life

"On the one hand, ISIS is deeply Wahhabist. On the other hand, it is ultra radical in a different way. It could be seen essentially as a corrective movement to contemporary Wahhabism."

But the Saudi Ikhwan approach to Islam did not die in the 1930s. It retreated, but it maintained its hold over parts of the system -- hence the duality that we observe today in the Saudi attitude towards ISIS.

On the one hand, ISIS is deeply Wahhabist. On the other hand, it is ultra radical in a different way. It could be seen essentially as a corrective movement to contemporary Wahhabism.

ISIS is a "post-Medina" movement: it looks to the actions of the first two Caliphs, rather than the Prophet Muhammad himself, as a source of emulation, and it forcefully denies the Saudis' claim of authority to rule.

As the Saudi monarchy blossomed in the oil age into an ever more inflated institution, the appeal of the Ikhwan message gained ground (despite King Faisal's modernization campaign). The "Ikhwan approach" enjoyed -- and still enjoys -- the support of many prominent men and women and sheikhs. In a sense, Osama bin Laden was precisely the representative of a late flowering of this Ikhwani approach.

Today, ISIS' undermining of the legitimacy of the King's legitimacy is not seen to be problematic, but rather a return to the true origins of the Saudi-Wahhab project.

In the collaborative management of the region by the Saudis and the West in pursuit of the many western projects (countering socialism, Ba'athism, Nasserism, Soviet and Iranian influence), western politicians have highlighted their chosen reading of Saudi Arabia (wealth, modernization and influence), but they chose to ignore the Wahhabist impulse.

After all, the more radical Islamist movements were perceived by Western intelligence services as being more effective in toppling the USSR in Afghanistan -- and in combatting out-of-favor Middle Eastern leaders and states.

Why should we be surprised then, that from Prince Bandar's Saudi-Western mandate to manage the insurgency in Syria against President Assad should have emerged a neo-Ikhwan type of violent, fear-inducing vanguard movement: ISIS? And why should we be surprised - knowing a little about Wahhabism -- that "moderate" insurgents in Syria would become rarer than a mythical unicorn? Why should we have imagined that radical Wahhabism would create moderates? Or why could we imagine that a doctrine of "One leader, One authority,

One mosque: submit to it, or be killed" could ever ultimately lead to moderation or tolerance?

Or, perhaps, we never imagined.

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PART 2

Middle East Time Bomb: The Real Aim of ISIS Is to Replace the Saud Family as the New Emirs of Arabia

Alastair Crooke, Fmr. MI-6 agent; Author, 'Resistance: The Essence of Islamic Revolution'

This article is Part II of Alastair Crooke's historical analysis of the roots of ISIS and its impact on the future of the Middle East.

BEIRUT -- ISIS is indeed a veritable time bomb inserted into the heart of the Middle East. But its destructive power is not as commonly understood. It is not with the "March of the Beheaders"; it is not with the killings; the seizure of towns and villages; the harshest of "justice" -- terrible though they are -- that its true explosive power lies. It is yet more potent than its exponential pull on young Muslims, its huge arsenal of weapons and its hundreds of millions of dollars.

"We should understand that there is really almost nothing that the West can now do about it but sit and watch."

Its real potential for destruction lies elsewhere -- in the implosion of Saudi Arabia as a foundation stone of the modern Middle East. We should understand that there is really almost nothing that the West can now do about it but sit and watch.

The clue to its truly explosive potential, as Saudi scholar Fouad Ibrahim has pointed out (but which has passed, almost wholly overlooked, or its significance has gone unnoticed), is ISIS' deliberate and intentional use in its doctrine -- of the language of Abd-al Wahhab, the 18th century founder, together with Ibn Saud, of Wahhabism and the Saudi project:

Abu Omar al-Baghdadi, the first "prince of the faithful" in the Islamic State of Iraq, in 2006 formulated, for instance, the principles of his prospective state ... Among its goals is disseminating monotheism "which is the purpose [for which humans were created] and [for which purpose they must be called] to Islam..." This language replicates exactly Abd-al Wahhab's formulation. And, not surprisingly, the latter's writings and Wahhabi commentaries on his works are widely distributed in the areas under ISIS' control and are made the subject of study sessions. Baghdadi subsequently was to note approvingly, "a generation of young men [have been] trained based on the forgotten doctrine of loyalty and disavowal."

And what is this "forgotten" tradition of "loyalty and disavowal?" It is Abd al-Wahhab's doctrine that belief in a sole (for him an anthropomorphic) God -- who was alone worthy of worship -- was in itself insufficient to render man or woman a Muslim?

He or she could be no true believer, unless additionally, he or she actively denied (and destroyed) any other subject of worship. The list of such potential subjects of idolatrous worship, which al-Wahhab condemned as idolatry, was so extensive that almost all Muslims were at risk of falling under his definition of "unbelievers." They therefore faced a choice: Either they convert to al-Wahhab's vision of Islam -- or be killed, and their wives, their

children and physical property taken as the spoils of jihad. Even to express doubts about this doctrine, al-Wahhab said, should occasion execution.

"Through its intentional adoption of this Wahhabist language, ISIS is knowingly lighting the fuse to a bigger regional explosion -- one that has a very real possibility of being ignited, and if it should succeed, will change the Middle East decisively."

The point Fuad Ibrahim is making, I believe, is not merely to reemphasize the extreme reductionism of al-Wahhab's vision, but to hint at something entirely different: That through its intentional adoption of this Wahhabist language, ISIS is knowingly lighting the fuse to a bigger regional explosion -- one that has a very real possibility of being ignited, and if it should succeed, will change the Middle East decisively.

For it was precisely this idealistic, puritan, proselytizing formulation by al-Wahhab that was "father" to the entire Saudi "project" (one that was violently suppressed by the Ottomans in 1818, but spectacularly resurrected in the 1920s, to become the Saudi Kingdom that we know today). But since its renaissance in the 1920s, the Saudi project has always carried within it, the "gene" of its own self-destruction.

THE SAUDI TAIL HAS WAGGED BRITAIN AND U.S. IN THE MIDDLE EAST

Paradoxically, it was a maverick British official, who helped embed the gene into the new state. The British official attached to Aziz, was one Harry St. John Philby (the father of the MI6 officer who spied for the Soviet KGB, Kim Philby). He was to become King Abd al-Aziz's close adviser, having resigned as a British official, and was until his death, a key member of the Ruler's Court. He, like Lawrence of Arabia, was an Arabist. He was also a convert to Wahhabi Islam and known as Sheikh Abdullah.

St. John Philby was a man on the make: he had determined to make his friend, Abd al-Aziz, the ruler of Arabia. Indeed, it is clear that in furthering this ambition he was not acting on official instructions. When, for example, he encouraged King Aziz to expand in northern Nejd, he was ordered to desist. But (as American author, Stephen Schwartz notes), Aziz was well aware that Britain had pledged repeatedly that the defeat of the Ottomans would produce an Arab state, and this no doubt, encouraged Philby and Aziz to aspire to the latter becoming its new ruler.

It is not clear exactly what passed between Philby and the Ruler (the details seem somehow to have been suppressed), but it would appear that Philby's vision was not confined to state-building in the conventional way, but rather was one of transforming the wider Islamic ummah (or community of believers) into a Wahhabist instrument that would entrench the al-Saud as Arabia's leaders. And for this to happen, Aziz needed to win British acquiescence (and much later, American endorsement). "This was the gambit that Abd al-Aziz made his own, with advice from Philby," notes Schwartz.

BRITISH GODFATHER OF SAUDI ARABIA

In a sense, Philby may be said to be "godfather" to this momentous pact by which the Saudi leadership would use its clout to "manage" Sunni Islam on behalf of western objectives (containing socialism, Ba'athism, Nasserism, Soviet influence, Iran, etc.) -- and in return, the West would acquiesce to Saudi Arabia's soft-power Wahhabisation of the Islamic ummah (with its concomitant destruction of Islam's intellectual traditions and diversity and its sowing of deep divisions within the Muslim world).

"In political and financial terms, the Saud-Philby strategy has been an astonishing success. But it was always rooted in British and American intellectual obtuseness: the refusal to see the dangerous 'gene' within the Wahhabist project, its latent potential to mutate, at any time, back into its original a bloody, puritan strain. In any event, this has just happened: ISIS is it."

As a result -- from then until now -- British and American policy has been bound to Saudi aims (as tightly as to their own ones), and has been heavily dependent on Saudi Arabia for direction in pursuing its course in the Middle East.

In political and financial terms, the Saud-Philby strategy has been an astonishing success (if taken on its own, cynical, self-serving terms). But it was always rooted in British and American intellectual obtuseness: the refusal to see the dangerous "gene" within the Wahhabist project, its latent potential to mutate, at any time, back into its original a bloody, puritan strain. In any event, this has just happened: ISIS is it.

Winning western endorsement (and continued western endorsement), however, required a change of mode: the "project" had to change from being an armed, proselytizing Islamic vanguard movement into something resembling statecraft. This was never going to be easy because of the inherent contradictions involved (puritan morality versus realpolitik and money) -- and as time has progressed, the problems of accommodating the "modernity" that statehood requires, has caused "the gene" to become more active, rather than become more inert.

Even Abd al-Aziz himself faced an allergic reaction: in the form of a serious rebellion from his own Wahhabi militia, the Saudi Ikhwan. When the expansion of control by the Ikhwan reached the border of territories controlled by Britain, Abd al-Aziz tried to restrain his militia (Philby was urging him to seek British patronage), but the Ikhwan, already critical of his use of modern technology (the telephone, telegraph and the machine gun), "were outraged by the abandonment of jihad for reasons of worldly realpolitik ... They refused to lay down their weapons; and instead rebelled against their king ... After a series of bloody clashes, they were crushed in 1929. Ikhwan members who had remained loyal, were later absorbed into the [Saudi] National Guard."

King Aziz's son and heir, Saud, faced a different form of reaction (less bloody, but more effective). Aziz's son was deposed from the throne by the religious establishment -- in favor of his brother Faisal -- because of his ostentatious and extravagant conduct. His lavish, ostentatious style, offended the religious establishment who expected the "Imam of Muslims," to pursue a pious, proselytizing lifestyle.

King Faisal, Saud's successor, in his turn, was shot by his nephew in 1975, who had appeared at Court ostensibly to make his oath of allegiance, but who instead, pulled out a pistol and shot the king in his head. The nephew had been perturbed by the encroachment of western beliefs and innovation into Wahhabi society, to the detriment of the original ideals of the Wahhabist project.

SEIZING THE GRAND MOSQUE IN 1979

Far more serious, however, was the revived Ikhwan of Juhayman al-Otaybi, which culminated in the seizure of the Grand Mosque by some 400-500 armed men and women in 1979. Juhayman was from the influential Otaybi tribe from the Nejd, which had led and been a principal element in the original Ikhwan of the 1920s.

Juhayman and his followers, many of whom came from the Medina seminary, had the tacit support, amongst other clerics, of Sheikh Abdel-Aziz Bin Baz, the former Mufti of Saudi Arabia. Juhayman stated that Sheikh Bin Baz never objected to his Ikhwan teachings (which were also critical of ulema laxity towards "disbelief"), but that bin Baz had blamed him mostly for harking on that "the ruling al-Saud dynasty had lost its legitimacy because it was corrupt, ostentatious and had destroyed Saudi culture by an aggressive policy of westernisation."

Significantly, Juhayman's followers preached their Ikhwani message in a number of mosques in Saudi Arabia initially without being arrested, but when Juhayman and a number of the Ikhwan finally were held for questioning in 1978. Members of the ulema (including bin Baz) cross-examined them for heresy, but then ordered their release because they saw them as being no more than traditionalists harkening back to the Ikhwan-- like Juhayman grandfather -- and therefore not a threat.

Even when the mosque seizure was defeated and over, a certain level of forbearance by the ulema for the rebels remained. When the government asked for a fatwa allowing for armed force to be used in the mosque, the language of bin Baz and other senior ulema was curiously restrained. The scholars did not declare Juhayman and his followers non-Muslims, despite their violation of the sanctity of the Grand Mosque, but only termed them al-jamaah al-musallahah (the armed group).

The group that Juhayman led was far from marginalized from important sources of power and wealth. In a sense, it swam in friendly, receptive waters. Juhayman's grandfather had been one of the leaders of the the original Ikhwan, and after the rebellion against Abdel Aziz, many of his grandfather's comrades in arms were absorbed into the National Guard -- indeed Juhayman himself had served within the Guard -- thus Juhayman was able to obtain weapons and military expertise from sympathizers in the National Guard, and the necessary arms and food to sustain the siege were pre-positioned, and hidden, within the Grand Mosque. Juhayman was also able to call on wealthy individuals to fund the enterprise.

ISIS VS. WESTERNIZED SAUDIS

The point of rehearsing this history is to underline how uneasy the Saudi leadership must be at the rise of ISIS in Iraq and Syria. Previous Ikhwani manifestations were suppressed -- but these all occurred inside the kingdom.

ISIS however, is a neo-Ikhwani rejectionist protest that is taking place outside the kingdom -- and which, moreover, follows the Juhayman dissidence in its trenchant criticism of the al-Saud ruling family.

This is the deep schism we see today in Saudi Arabia, between the modernizing current of which King Abdullah is a part, and the "Juhayman" orientation of which bin Laden, and the Saudi supporters of ISIS and the Saudi religious establishment are a part. It is also a schism that exists within the Saudi royal family itself.

According to the Saudi-owned Al-Hayat newspaper, in July 2014 "an opinion poll of Saudis [was] released on social networking sites, claiming that 92 percent of the target group believes that 'IS conforms to the values of Islam and Islamic law.'" The leading Saudi commentator, Jamal Khashoggi, recently warned of ISIS' Saudi supporters who "watch from the shadows."

There are angry youths with a skewed mentality and understanding of life and sharia, and they are canceling a heritage of centuries and the supposed gains of a modernization that hasn't been completed. They turned into rebels, emirs and a caliph invading a vast area of our land. They are hijacking our children's minds and canceling borders. They reject all rules and legislations, throwing it [a]way ... for their vision of politics, governance, life, society and economy. [For] the citizens of the self-declared "commander of the faithful," or Caliph, you have no other choice ... They don't care if you stand out among your people and if you are an educated man, or a lecturer, or a tribe leader, or a religious leader, or an active politician or even a judge ... You must obey the commander of the faithful and pledge the oath of allegiance to him. When their policies are questioned, Abu Obedia al-Jazrawi yells, saying: "Shut up. Our reference is the book and the Sunnah and that's it."

"What did we do wrong?" Khashoggi asks. With 3,000-4,000 Saudi fighters in the Islamic State today, he advises of the need to "look inward to explain ISIS' rise". Maybe it is time, he says, to admit "our political mistakes," to "correct the mistakes of our predecessors."

MODERNIZING KING THE MOST VULNERABLE

The present Saudi king, Abdullah, paradoxically is all the more vulnerable precisely because he has been a modernizer. The King has curbed the influence of the religious institutions and the religious police -- and importantly has permitted the four Sunni schools of jurisprudence to be used, by those who adhere to them (al-Wahhab, by contrast, objected to all other schools of jurisprudence other than his own).

"The key political question is whether the simple fact of ISIS' successes, and the full manifestation (flowering) of all the original pieties and vanguardism of the archetypal impulse, will stimulate and activate the dissenter 'gene' -- within the Saudi kingdom. If it does, and Saudi Arabia is engulfed by the ISIS fervor, the Gulf will never be the same again. Saudi Arabia will deconstruct and the Middle East will be unrecognizable."

It is even possible too for Shiite residents of eastern Saudi Arabia to invoke Ja'afri jurisprudence and to turn to Ja'afari Shiite clerics for rulings. (In clear contrast, al-Wahhab held a particular animosity towards the Shiite and held them to be apostates. As recently as the 1990s, clerics such as bin Baz -- the former Mufti -- and Abdullah Jibrin reiterated the customary view that the Shiite were infidels).

Some contemporary Saudi ulema would regard such reforms as constituting almost a provocation against Wahhabist doctrines, or at the very least, another example of westernization. ISIS, for example, regards any who seek jurisdiction other than that offered by the Islamic State itself to be guilty of disbelief -- since all such "other" jurisdictions embody innovation or "borrowings" from other cultures in its view.

The key political question is whether the simple fact of ISIS' successes, and the full manifestation (flowering) of all the original pieties and vanguardism of the archetypal impulse, will stimulate and activate the dissenter 'gene' -- within the Saudi kingdom.

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"They hold up a mirror to Saudi society that seems to reflect back to them an image of 'purity' lost"

In short, this is the nature of the time bomb tossed into the Middle East. The ISIS allusions to Abd al-Wahhab and Juhayman (whose dissident writings are circulated within ISIS) present a powerful provocation: they hold up a mirror to Saudi society that seems to reflect back to them an image of "purity" lost and early beliefs and certainties displaced by shows of wealth and indulgence.

This is the ISIS "bomb" hurled into Saudi society. King Abdullah -- and his reforms -- are popular, and perhaps he can contain a new outbreak of Ikhwani dissidence. But will that option remain a possibility after his death?

And here is the difficulty with evolving U.S. policy, which seems to be one of "leading from behind" again -- and looking to Sunni states and communities to coalesce in the fight against ISIS (as in Iraq with the Awakening Councils).

It is a strategy that seems highly implausible. Who would want to insert themselves into this sensitive intra-Saudi rift? And would concerted Sunni attacks on ISIS make King Abdullah's situation better, or might it inflame and anger domestic Saudi dissidence even further? So whom precisely does ISIS threaten? It could not be clearer. It does not directly threaten the West (though westerners should remain wary, and not tread on this particular scorpion).

The Saudi Ikhwani history is plain: As Ibn Saud and Abd al-Wahhab made it such in the 18th century; and as the Saudi Ikhwan made it such in the 20th century. ISIS' real target must be the Hijaz -- the seizure of Mecca and Medina -- and the legitimacy that this will confer on ISIS as the new Emirs of Arabia.

The New York Times
8 Sep 2014

New U.N. Human Rights Chief Urges Action to End Conflicts in Syria and Iraq

By NICK CUMMING-BRUCE

GENEVA — Zeid Ra'ad al-Hussein began his tenure on Monday as the United Nations human rights chief with a strongly worded statement in which he forcefully condemned Islamic extremism and urged international action to end conflicts in Syria and Iraq.

In his first speech to the United Nations Human Rights Council in Geneva, Mr. Zeid, a Jordanian prince who has dispensed with his royal title as incompatible with his new post, identified the conflicts in Syria and Iraq as "the immediate and urgent priority of the international community."

Pledging to be "firm, yet always fair, critical of states where necessary," Mr. Zeid, the first Muslim to assume the post as the United Nations high commissioner for human rights, delivered a 40-minute statement. He called for the protection of civilians by all parties to "the deplorable conflict" in Ukraine; praised investigations into human rights abuses in North Korea and Sri Lanka; highlighted the "chain of human rights violations" committed by Australia in its treatment of migrants; and voiced concern about the United States' detention of unaccompanied child migrants.

Conflict has reduced Syria to "a slaughterhouse," Mr. Zeid said, and a state created by the Sunni militant group known as the Islamic State in Iraq and Syria would be "a harsh, meanspirited house of blood." The group's brutal actions, like those of Muslim extremists across the Middle East and Africa, he added, offered "only annihilation to Muslims, Christians, Jews and others, altogether the rest of humanity, who believe differently to them."

The Israeli-Palestinian conflict provided "another example of the need to end persistent discrimination and impunity," Mr. Zeid said, highlighting the "particularly devastating toll in death, suffering and destruction."

Israel has a right to live free and secure from indiscriminate rocket fire, he said, but Palestinians in Gaza and the West Bank have a right to live "without conflict, without a blockade, indeed without the wide range of daily human rights infringements that are generated by military occupation, illegal settlements, excessive use of force, home demolitions, and the wall that continues to be constructed."

Mr. Zeid, formerly Jordan's ambassador to the United Nations, also addressed the paralysis of world powers in the United Nations Security Council. Their use of vetoes to block actions that would prevent atrocities is "a form of cruelty," especially when they fail to offer alternatives for addressing grievous human suffering, he said.

Mr. Zeid said he would participate in a ministerial meeting this month to consider a code of conduct for the permanent members of the Security Council, continuing the frequent interaction with the Council by his predecessor, Navi Pillay.

Ms. Pillay had faced criticism from many governments in her battle for the rights of victims,

Mr. Zeid observed. He praised her for being one of the most formidable high commissioners for human rights, and “one of the greatest senior officials the U.N. has ever had.”

The New York Times
8 Sep 2014

ISIS Kills 17 in Attack on Rival Sunni Tribesmen in Iraq

By KAREEM FAHIM and ALI HAMZA

BAGHDAD — Members of the Islamic State in Iraq and Syria attacked Sunni tribal fighters north of Baghdad early Monday, killing at least 17 people as the militants showed new determination to punish Sunnis who have resisted the ISIS onslaught into parts of northern Iraq.

Using an explosive-laden Humvee, apparently captured from the Iraqi Army, the militants assaulted an entrance to the town of Dhuluiya, about 50 miles north of Baghdad, according to local tribal leaders.

Some of the district's most prominent Sunni tribes, including the Al-Jabour, have been openly fighting the Sunni extremists of ISIS for the last two months. The participation of Sunni fighters in the resistance to ISIS is seen as a key to halting its advance. Over the weekend, Sunni tribal fighters in Anbar Province joined Iraqi Army troops in attacking ISIS fighters in towns near the Haditha Dam as United States warplanes bombed the militants.

The fighting on Monday came as Iraqi politicians argued over the complexion of a new government, which has been rumored for days but is said to have been repeatedly delayed over disputes about key cabinet posts. Iraq's incoming prime minister, Haider al-Abadi, who is set to replace Nuri Kamal al-Maliki, is required to name a cabinet by Tuesday.

Iraq's Western allies have called for an "inclusive" government, insisting that new leaders seek to reverse the divisive legacy of Mr. Maliki, whose Shiite-led government was accused by Sunnis of marginalizing and antagonizing them. As Iraqi cities fell to ISIS this summer, pressure intensified on Mr. Maliki to step down, from inside and outside Iraq.

There was no assurance that a new government would quiet the crisis. Lists of possible cabinet members that have circulated over the past few days have been full of familiar names, suggesting a reshuffling rather than a revitalization.

Iraq's Parliament speaker said members would vote on a cabinet during Monday's session, though many anticipated a further delay. Even so, members of the Iraqi National Symphony Orchestra sat in the chamber on Monday, preparing in case there was something to celebrate.

"We are ready to play the national anthem whenever they form the government," the deputy manager said.

The Daily Beast
19 Aug 2014

On ISIS, Pope Francis Is No Crusader

Elizabeth Stoker Bruenig

It's true that the Pope is worried about religious minorities that are threatened with extinction from ISIS, but it's absurd to say that he's calling for war, much less a medieval-style crusade.

To listen to the wave of breathless media coverage of Pope Francis' recent remarks regarding intervention in Iraq on behalf of persecuted minorities, one would think the pontiff had expressed unqualified enthusiasm about the use of military force. Numerous outlets reported that he had called for "military action" against the ISIS terror group. Writing at Vox, Max Fisher went so far as to compare Francis' position on intervention to a call for another crusade.

"There is good precedent for this," Fisher wrote. "During the Middle Ages, between 1096 and 1272 AD, popes also endorsed the use of Western military action to destroy Middle Eastern caliphates. Those were known as the crusades; there were nine, which means that this would be number 10."

To earn an interpretation like that, Francis surely called for heads on spikes and Christian standards draped over the gates of Iraqi cities, right? But the Pope's comments on Monday were in reality characteristically thoughtful and measured, providing little grist for the crusade rumor mill.

"In these cases, where there is an unjust aggression, I can only say that it is licit to stop the unjust aggressor...I underscore the verb 'stop,'" Francis said. "I'm not saying 'bomb' or 'make war,' just 'stop.' And the means that can be used to stop them must be evaluated...One nation alone cannot judge how you stop this, how you stop an unjust aggressor."

First, it's important to clarify what Pope Francis is requesting be stopped. He is not indicating that ISIS should be stopped in general terms, but that they unjust aggression against minority religious groups should be stopped – a feat that could be accomplished by removing those persecuted groups from ISIS occupied territories either permanently or temporarily.

Francis' emphasis on unjust aggression as the problem to pinpoint also underscores the fact that his interest is in human dignity rather than the preservation of a specific religious community. Unlike the typical framing of, say, a medieval crusade, Pope Francis has openly objected the ill treatment of *all* religious minorities under assault from ISIS, a theme these recent comments bear out well. And his universal appeal for the safety of threatened minorities doesn't match up with the Cross-versus-crescent rhetoric summoned to mind by accusations of crusading.

It's also worthwhile to pay serious attention to Francis' unwillingness to assign special favor to any particular strategy of intervention. He was especially careful to note that many "wars of conquest" have been carried out under the banner of humanitarian intervention, and emphasized that the participation of various global powers will be key to ensuring whatever intervention takes place does not degenerate into a self-serving military action.

Pope Francis' repeated prayers for peace and calls for the protection of groups facing genocide recalls Pope John Paul II's great sympathy for Muslims similarly persecuted during the Bosnian War of the 1990s. In 1994, Pope John Paul II demanded that "all forms of action aimed at disarming the aggressor" be carried out in Bosnia, where Serbian Christians were slaughtering Bosnian Muslims, and systematically raping women and girls. The Vatican decried the "utterly shameful cowardliness" of the international community in putting off intervention for so long – evidently a pattern Pope Francis is unwilling to see revisited.

For his efforts in encouraging humanitarian intervention and supporting oppressed religious minorities, Pope John Paul II has enjoyed enormous popularity among the people of Bosnia and Herzegovina, who erected a monument to the pontiff in 2011 to honor his commitment to the defense of peace and human dignity.

Both Pope John Paul II and Pope Francis have deployed in their ministry against genocide similar emphases on peace, international collaboration, and concern for human dignity. A side-by-side comparison of Pope Francis' remarks with medieval papal bulls agitating for crusades would reveal very little similarity in terms tone or content, and the suggestion that Pope Francis is a crusader in disguise is still dangerously irresponsible.

There is already some agitation for what would amount to a Christian assault on ISIS based mainly on religious grounds, and it seems unlikely that wiser policy will be produced by creating the delusion of Christian consensus on unilateral American military force aimed at destroying ISIS entirely. What Pope Francis' contribution to our public conversation about how to respond to the crimes against humanity currently taking place in Iraq offers is nuance and reflectiveness – both qualities are washed out by clumsily filing him away as a nouveau crusader. For Americans, decisions about intervention abroad hearken back to recent bad experiences in Iraq and Afghanistan, which is precisely why we should take Francis' advice seriously when he talks about international collaboration and a sincere evaluation of what methods to use in the protection of minorities.

Generally, Pope Francis enjoys broad public reach, and as his ministry has remained committed to the needs of the vulnerable and impoverished, his input has grown in moral credibility. It's a shame that such a well-considered message – one that clearly seeks to *avoid* repeating mistakes of the past – should be given such a facile and bad-faith reception.

In twenty years, Pope Francis may well be honored just like John Paul II for supporting the abused even when political currents were murky and ambivalent. And when survivors of genocide are thanking him for remaining faithful to their human dignity, all this clickbaiting about crusades will look very strange.

The New York Times
8 Sep 2014

Syria and Iraq Called Urgent by New U.N. Rights Chief

By NICK CUMMING-BRUCE

GENEVA — Zeid Ra'ad al-Hussein began his tenure on Monday as the United Nations human rights chief with a strongly worded statement in which he condemned Islamic extremism and urged international action to end conflicts in Syria and Iraq.

In his first speech to the United Nations Human Rights Council in Geneva, Mr. Zeid, a Jordanian prince who has dispensed with his royal title as incompatible with his new post, identified the conflicts in Syria and Iraq as "the immediate and urgent priority of the international community."

Pledging to be "firm, yet always fair, critical of states where necessary," Mr. Zeid, the first Muslim to assume the post as the United Nations high commissioner for human rights, delivered a 40-minute statement. He called for the protection of civilians by all parties to "the deplorable conflict" in Ukraine; praised investigations into human rights abuses in North Korea and Sri Lanka; highlighted the "chain of human rights violations" committed by Australia in its treatment of migrants; and voiced concern about the United States' detention of unaccompanied child migrants.

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Ms. Pillay had faced criticism from many governments in her battle for the rights of victims, Mr. Zeid observed. He praised her as being "one of the greatest senior officials the U.N. has ever had."

Politico
7 Sep 2014

President Obama to detail ISIL fight in speech to nation

By JENNIFER EPSTEIN

President Barack Obama will outline to the nation on Wednesday his administration's plans for fighting the Islamic State of Iraq and the Levant and does not expect to ask Congress for approval to act, he said in an interview that aired Sunday.

"I'm preparing the country to make sure that we deal with a threat from ISIL," Obama said in an interview conducted at the White House on Saturday to mark Chuck Todd's first show as moderator of NBC's "Meet the Press."

"There's going to be an economic element to this. There's going to be a political element to it. There's going to be a military element to it," he said, without going into more detail. "And what I want people to understand, though, is that over the course of months, we are going to be able to not just blunt the momentum of ISIL. We are going to systematically degrade their capabilities. We're going to shrink the territory that they control. And ultimately we're going to defeat 'em."

After months of assessing the threat posed by ISIL and several weeks of securing U.S. personnel in Iraq, "the next phase is now to start going on some offense," Obama said, and he'll use Wednesday's speech to explain to Americans how he intends to move forward.

The bulk of the interview focused on ISIL and other threats in the Middle East, though it also touched on his announcement Saturday to delay executive action on immigration reform, his case for why voters should support Democrats in the midterm elections and whether he's fatigued after more than five and a half years in office.

The president's speech on ISIL will be a chance for him to clarify his plans for fighting the terrorist group after conflicting messages from the administration, including his "we don't have a strategy yet" comments late last month. It will also come as the administration works on solidifying international support and, it's expected, as Iraq's new government is finalized.

"This is not going to be an announcement about U.S. ground troops," Obama told Todd. "This is not the equivalent of the Iraq War. What this is is similar to the kinds of counterterrorism campaigns that we've been engaging in consistently over the last five, six, seven years. And the good news is that because of American leadership, we have I believe, a broad-based coalition internationally and regionally to be able to deal with the problem."

Though he intends to explain his plans to the American public and to lawmakers, the president said he believes he has the authority to act without congressional approval.

"I'm confident that I have the authorization that I need to protect the American people. And I'm always going to do what's necessary to protect the American people," he said. "But I do think it's important for Congress to understand what the plan is, to have buy-in, to debate it."

The speech "will allow Congress, I think, to understand very clearly and very specifically

what it is that we are doing but also what we're not doing. We're not looking at sending in 100,000 American troops," Obama continued. "We are going to be as part of an international coalition, carrying out air strikes in support of work on the ground by Iraqi troops, Kurdish troops. We are going to be helping to put together a plan for them, so that they can start retaking territory that ISIL had taken over."

Obama has been insistent that U.S. troops will not be on the ground to fight ISIL in Iraq or Syria, and he told Todd that he expects Syrians to fight the group on their own land.

"In terms of controlling territory, we're going to have to develop a moderate Sunni opposition that can control territory and that we can work with," he said. "The notion that the United States should be putting boots on the ground, I think would be a profound mistake. And I want to be very clear and very explicit about that."

The interview was the first extended sit-down that Obama has done since before launching airstrikes against ISIL targets in Iraq in early August, and Todd used it as an opportunity to press the president on a quote from an early-2014 interview with *The New Yorker* in which Obama seemed to compare ISIL to a junior-varsity basketball team.

"Keep in mind I wasn't specifically referring to ISIL. I've said that, regionally, there were a whole series of organizations that were focused primarily locally. Weren't focused on homeland, because I think a lot of us, when we think about terrorism, the model is Osama bin Laden and 9/11," Obama said, offering a defense similar to the one that has earned White House press secretary Josh Earnest low marks from fact checkers who argue that the president's reference to Fallujah in the magazine article suggests he was discussing ISIL in Iraq.

The interview also touched on politics and the president's argument for Democrats keeping their majority in the Senate this fall.

"There's a sharp difference between the Democratic agenda and the Republican agenda. And the American people need to know that," Obama said, citing Democrats' support for raising the federal minimum wage, doing more to ensure that women are paid fairly for their work, funding infrastructure projects and more.

While "it's unlikely that I get a lot of these bills to my desk" as long as Republicans keep their majority in the House, the president said, "it makes a big difference if we've got at least one branch in Congress that is presenting these ideas, making arguments."

If Democrats are able to maintain control of the Senate, it would "send a message to Republicans that people want to get stuff done," Obama said. "Their strategy of just obstructing and saying no to every piece of legislation that might help middle-class families, that might create ladders of opportunity, that that is an agenda that the American people reject."

If voters are able to successfully convey to Republicans this fall that they are tired of obstruction, Obama continued, "then you possibly have two years where we can get a whole bunch of stuff done."

CNN
8 Sep 2014

Obama: U.S. to 'start going on some offense' in ISIS fight

By Leigh Ann Caldwell and Elliott C. McLaughlin, CNN

(CNN) -- President Barack Obama will address the country Wednesday to explain to the nation "what our game plan is going forward" in the fight against ISIS.

In an interview that aired Sunday on NBC's "Meet the Press," Obama expressed confidence that the United States, with help from regional partners, will be able to wipe out the terror organization.

"I just want the American people to understand the nature of the threat and how we're going to deal with it and to have confidence that we'll be able to deal with it," the President told interviewer Chuck Todd.

He said action will include military, diplomatic and economic components. He laid out a three-stage plan that starts with actions the U.S. has already taken: gathering increased intelligence on ISIS, and using airstrikes to protect American personnel, critical Iraqi infrastructure like the Mosul Dam, and cities such as Irbil in Iraqi Kurdistan.

U.S. airstrikes target ISIS fighters near 2nd-largest dam in Iraq

"The next phase is now to start going on some offense," he said. "We have to get an Iraqi government in place, and I'm optimistic that next week we should be able to get that done."

He said his speech won't announce the involvement of U.S. ground troops. "We're not looking at sending 100,000 American troops," he vowed.

The President gave his most direct and detailed assessment of ISIS since the terrorist group has brutally decapitated two American journalists and killed thousands of Iraqis. It is a vastly different message than he gave nearly two weeks ago, when he said the U.S. didn't have a strategy "yet" to deal with ISIS in Syria, and in January, when he called it and other groups the JV team.

"Well, they're not a JV team," Obama said in Sunday's "Meet the Press" interview.

The President received praise from recent critics who had said he was too timid as the scope, depth and capabilities of ISIS continue to grow.

"I want to congratulate the President. He is now on offense," Sen. Dianne Feinstein, chairwoman of the Senate Intelligence Committee, said on CNN's "State of the Union."

"It's overdue, but the President is now there," the California Democrat added.

Her counterpart in the House, Rep. Mike Rogers, R-Michigan, chairman of the House Intelligence Committee, echoed Feinstein's sentiment, also on CNN. "This is the toughest talk that we have heard from the President, and I agree with Sen. Feinstein -- that's a good thing because they are a threat."

But not everyone applauded. Sen. Marco Rubio of Florida, who is considering a run for the Republican presidential nomination in 2016 and has criticized Obama for not acting quickly or strongly enough, said, "American foreign policy is in the hands of someone who does not know what he's doing."

"I believe this president has committed a presidential malpractice in his foreign policy," Rubio added on CBS News' "Face the Nation."

Congressional 'buy-in'

Congress returns to Washington this week from a five-week break and will immediately face questions about ISIS.

Obama said he will meet with members of Congress on Tuesday to discuss the administration's strategy, let lawmakers "have buy-in" and debate the plan. But asked by Todd if he was seeking congressional authorization of his strategy, Obama appeared to say no.

"I'm confident that I've got the authorization that I need to protect the American people," he said.

But Sen. Ted Cruz of Texas, who is also considering a 2016 presidential run, said on ABC's "This Week" that any additional military action "should absolutely take congressional approval."

His colleagues in the House, however, didn't agree, saying the President has the constitutional authority to act without Congressional authorization.

The top Republican on the House Homeland Security Committee, Rep. Peter King, R-New York, said, "I believe as commander in chief he has the absolute power to carry out these attacks."

Democratic Rep. Adam Smith of Washington agreed, saying the President doesn't need authorization but that "it would be better if Congress would authorize it."

He added, however, that it would be "extraordinarily difficult" to get through the partisan body, especially less than two months before an election.

Syria

While the U.S. plan to help Iraqi and Kurdish troops take back areas under ISIS control is key to defeating the militants, Obama said the strategy will also have economic and political prongs.

His plan will involve working to "attract back Sunni tribes that may have felt that they had no connection to a Baghdad government that was ignoring their grievances."

As for the military, he insisted U.S. troops will not take the lead.

"We don't have the resources" to "occupy" numerous countries, he said, so a more "sustainable strategy ... means the boots on the ground have to be Iraqi."

But what's unclear still is if he will authorize airstrikes in Syria.

ISIS gained power and strength there trying to defeat Syrian President Bashar al-Assad in that country's complex civil war, and foreign policy hawks have been pushing for the U.S. to strike ISIS command centers and weapons stockpiles.

Obama didn't indicate in the interview aired Sunday whether he was going to move forward with airstrikes but said the U.S. will "need to put more resources" into vetted groups that oppose both al-Assad and ISIS in Syria.

"We're going to have to develop a moderate Sunni opposition that can control territory and that we can work with," he said, insisting there will be no U.S. troops on the ground. "The notion that the United States should be putting boots on the ground, I think, would be a profound mistake. And I want to be very clear and very explicit about that."

"The boots on the ground have to be Syrian," he added.

The U.S. has no plans to move forward alone. After a NATO summit in Wales last week, the President announced the support of nine countries that are committed to pushing back against ISIS. He said his next effort will be to obtain the support of allies in the region. Secretary of State John Kerry is going to spend the upcoming week attempting to gain support from Saudi Arabia, Jordan, Turkey and the United Arab Emirates, the President said.

As strategy firms up, U.S. courts partners to target ISIS

Threat to the U.S.

The President maintains that the terror group, which gained power in war-torn Syria and expanded into Iraq, is not an immediate threat to the U.S. But he noted that "over time" it could become a "serious threat to the homeland" if it is able to continue to expand territory under its control while amassing arms and fighters, especially Western fighters.

Wednesday's speech, which will come a day before the anniversary of the September 11, 2001, attacks, will help the American public better grasp the administration's plan, he said.

"What I want people to understand is that over the course of months, we are going to be able to not just blunt the momentum of (ISIS), we are going to systematically degrade their capabilities, we're going to shrink the territory that they control and ultimately, we're going to defeat them," Obama said.

**NBC News
7 Sep 2014
Meet the Press**

[Click here: President Barack Obama's Full Interview With NBC's Chuck Todd - NBC News.com](http://www.nbcnews.com/meet-the-press/president-barack-obamas-full-interview-nbcs-chuck-todd-n197616)

<http://www.nbcnews.com/meet-the-press/president-barack-obamas-full-interview-nbcs-chuck-todd-n197616>

Below is the transcript of that part the interview with President Barack Obama on NBC's Meet the Press that pertains to ISIS.

CHUCK TODD:

Mr. President, welcome back to your 12th appearance on Meet the Press.

PRESIDENT OBAMA:

Great to see you.

CHUCK TODD:

Thanks for doing this. We start with a very basic question. Are you preparing the country to go back to war?

PRESIDENT OBAMA:

I'm preparing the country to make sure that we deal with a threat from ISIL. Keep in mind that this is something that we know how to do. We've been dealing with terrorist threats for quite some time. This administration has systematically dismantled Al Qaeda in the FATA. We just yesterday announced the fact that we had taken out the top leader of Al-Shabaab the terrorist-- organization in Somalia.

ISIL poses a broader threat because of its territorial ambitions in Iraq and Syria. But the good news is coming back from the most recent NATO meeting is the entire international community understands that this is something that has to be dealt with.

So what I have done over the last several months is, first and foremost, make sure that we got eyes on the problem, that we shifted resources, intelligence, reconnaissance. We did an assessment on the ground. The second step was to make sure that we protected American personnel, our embassies, our consulates. That included taking air strikes to ensure that towns like Erbil were not overrun, critical infrastructure, like the Mosul Dam was protected, and that we were able to engage in key humanitarian assistance programs that have saved thousands of lives.

The next phase is now to start going on some offense. We have to get an Iraqi government in place. And I'm optimistic that next week, we should be able to get that done. And I will then meet with congressional leaders on Tuesday. On Wednesday, I'll make a speech and describe what our game plan's going to be going forward.

But this is not going to be an announcement about U.S. ground troops. This is not the equivalent of the Iraq war. What this is is similar to the kinds of counterterrorism campaigns that we've been engaging in consistently over the last five, six, seven years. And the good news is that because of American leadership, we have I believe, a broad-based coalition internationally and regionally to be able to deal with the problem.

CHUCK TODD:

What are you asking of the American people on Wednesday? You say you're giving a speech. That's the type of thing, I assume, you're preparing the country for something. What are you asking of them? What do you want--what do you want the American people to receive?

PRESIDENT OBAMA:

Well more than that, I just want the American people to understand the nature of the threat and how we're going to deal with it and to have confidence that we'll be able to deal with it.

CHUCK TODD:

You realize you're giving that speech the day before the 13th anniversary of 9/11.

PRESIDENT OBAMA:

But right. And I--I want everybody to understand that we have not seen any immediate intelligence about threats to the homeland from ISIL. That's not what this is about. What it's about is an organization that, if allowed to control significant amounts of territory, to amass more resources, more arms to attract more foreign fighters, including from areas like Europe, who have Europeans who have visas and then can travel to the United States unimpeded, that over time, that can be a serious threat to the homeland.

In-- in the more immediate term, it's an imm-- it's a threat to friends, partners in the region and is causing all kinds of hardship. And we've seen the savagery not just in terms of how they dealt with the two Americans that had been taken hostage but the killing of thousands of innocents in-- in Iraq thousands of innocents in Syria, the kidnapping of women the complete disruption of entire villages.

So what I'm going to be ask-- asking the American people to understand is, number one, this is a serious threat. Number two, we have the capacity to deal with it. Here's how we're going to deal with it. I am going to be asking Congress to make sure that they understand and support what our plan is. And it's going to require some resources, I suspect, above what we are currently doing in the region--

CHUCK TODD:

This is asking Congress for a vote, an authorization of your strategy. This is not a what-- what does that mean?

PRESIDENT OBAMA:

Well, I-- I-- I'm confident that I have the authorization that I need to protect the American people. And I'm always going to do what's necessary to protect the American people. But I do think it's important for Congress to understand what the plan is, to have buy in, to debate it.

And that's why we've been consulting with Congress throughout. And this speech will allow Congress, I think, to understand very clearly and very specifically what it is that we are doing but also what we're not doing. We're not looking at sending in 100,000 American troops.

We are going to be as part of an international coalition, carrying out air strikes in support of work on the ground by Iraqi troops, Kurdish troops. We are going to be helping to put together a plan for them, so that they can start retaking territory that ISIL had taken over.

We are going to have to work with our regional partners to attract back Sunni tribes that may have felt that they had no connection to a Baghdad government that was ignoring their grievances. And so there's going to be an economic element to this. There's going to be a political element to it. There's going to be a military element to it. And what I want people to understand, though, is that over the course of months, we are going to be able to not just blunt the momentum of ISIL. We are going to systematically degrade their capabilities. We're going to shrink the territory that they control. And ultimately we're going to defeat 'em.

CHUCK TODD:

Long way, long way from when you described them as a JV team.

PRESIDENT OBAMA:

Well, I--

CHUCK TODD:

Was that bad intelligence or your misjudgment?

PRESIDENT OBAMA:

Keep-- keep-- keep in mind I wasn't specifically referring to ISIL. I've said that, regionally, there were a whole series of organizations that were focused primarily locally. Weren't focused on homeland, because I think a lot of us, when we think about terrorism, the model is Osama bin Laden and 9/11. And the point that I was--

CHUCK TODD:

You don't believe these people--

PRESIDENT OBAMA:

Not yet. But they-- they can evolve. And I was very specific at that time. What I said was, not every regional terrorist organization is automatically a threat to us that would call for a major offensive. But what is absolutely clear in ISIL, which started as Al Qaeda in Iraq and

arose out of the U.S. invasion there and was contained because of the enormous efforts of our troops there then shifted to Syria, has metastasized, has grown. And now we're going to have to deal with--

CHUCK TODD:

They're not a JV team.

PRESIDENT OBAMA:

Well, they're not a JV team. But keep in mind that we anticipated some of these problems in the speech that I gave at West Point you know, several months ago, where I specifically said, our goal should not be to think that we can occupy every country where there's a terrorist organization.

Our goal has to be to partner more effectively with governments that are committed to-- pushing back against the kind of extremism that ISIL represents. And that's going to require us to do things a little bit differently. We're going to have to work smarter.

We're going to have to train the military there more capably. We've got to do more effective diplomatic work to eliminate the the schism between Sunni and Shia that has been fueling so much of the violence in Syria, in Iraq. And so we put together a plan that is compatible with the kind of work that we're doing now.

CHUCK TODD:

You've not said the word, "Syria," so far in our conversation. Obviously, if you're going to defeat ISIS, you have used very much stronger language. It's gone through the week during your trip to Wales. You got to go to Syria in some form or another.

You've ruled out boots on the ground. And I'm curious, have you only ruled them out simply for domestic political reasons? Or is there another reason you've ruled out American boots on the ground? Because your own-- your own guys have said, "You can't defeat ISIS with air strikes alone."

PRESIDENT OBAMA:

Well, they're absolutely right about that. But you also cannot, over the long term or even the medium term, deal with this problem by having the United States serially occupy various countries all around the Middle East. We don't have the resources. It puts enormous strains on our military. And at some point, we leave. And then things blow up again. So we--

CHUCK TODD:

That's what happened with Iraq.

PRESIDENT OBAMA:

--so-- so we've got to have a more sustainable strategy, which means the boots on the ground have to be Iraqi.

CHUCK TODD:

What about Syria--

PRESIDENT OBAMA:

And-- and in Syria, the boots on the ground have to be Syrian. And that's why--

CHUCK TODD:

Who?

PRESIDENT OBAMA:

Well we have a Free Syrian Army and a moderate opposition that we have steadily been working with but we have vetted. They have been on the defensive, not just from ISIL, but also from the Assad regime. And what-- you know, if you recall, at the West Point speech that I gave, I said, we need to put more resources into the moderate opposition in part because, unless we have people we can work with who are Sunni in these Sunni regions, then we're going to continue to have these problems.

And so the-- the strategy both for Iraq and for Syria is that we will hunt down ISIL members and assets wherever they are. I will reserve the right to always protect the American people and go after folks who are trying to hurt us wherever they are.

But in terms of controlling territory, we're going to have to develop a moderate Sunni opposition that can control territory and that we can work with. The notion that the United States should be putting boots on the ground, I think would be a profound mistake. And I want to be very clear and very explicit about that.

CHUCK TODD:

I-- I got a somewhat snarky email from a-- from a casual viewer who said, "The United States gives a lotta military aid to Saudi Arabia. It's about time they use it." What do you say to that?

PRESIDENT OBAMA:

Well, I think that it is absolutely true that we're going to need Sunni states to step up, not just Saudi Arabia, our partners like Jordan, the United Arab Emirates, Turkey. They need to be involved. This is their neighborhood. The dangers that are posed are-- are more directed at them right now than they are us.

And that's part of the conversation that John Kerry's going to be having this week. I sent him there after we left-- the NATO meeting in Wales. And the good news is, I think, for the, perhaps the first time, you have absolute clarity that the problem for Sunni states in the region, many of whom are our allies, is not simply Iran. It's not simply a Sunni-Shia issue.

Sunni extremism, as represented by ISIL, is the biggest danger that they face right now. And with that understanding, it gives us the capacity for them to start getting more active and more involved. And by the way, some of that's military. But some of it is giving political

support to Baghdad and strengthening relations with Shia leaders in Baghdad. Some of it is reaching out to the Sunni tribes in Iraq and identifying who we can work with, so that they can fight their own battles to free villages and regions that, you know, where they live. So they've got a big role to play. And, finally, a strategic messaging. One of the things we've seen about ISIL is they're really good on social media.

They--they understand how to -- message to disaffected youth throughout the Arab world and throughout the Sunni world what they're doing. And the question is, when are the moderate Sunni states and leadership going to work systematically to say, "what ISIL represents isn't Islam." It is an abortion-- a distortion-- an abomination of that-- that has, you know, somehow tied Islam to the kind of nihilistic thinking that any civilized nation should-- should eliminate.

CHUCK TODD:

Did you-- did you see those messages they sent to you, naming you, when they-- when they-- when they beheaded those American journalists?

PRESIDENT OBAMA:

Yes.

CHUCK TODD:

They sent messages addressing you personally. Did you watch 'em?

PRESIDENT OBAMA:

Did I-- I was-- I review-- as part of our overall counterterrorism effort, I review all the social media that many of these groups. And then these are-- this isn't the first organization to deploy social media. This is increasingly the way that they're recruiting, particularly among foreign fighters. And we need a much more effective counter-narrative. And it can't come from us. I mean, because if I--

CHUCK TODD:

I'm just curious. You know, when they address you like that and they behead an American, I mean, does it-- what-- how does that impact you?

PRESIDENT OBAMA:

Well-- you know, when you-- it's not so much how it affects me personally. It's thinking about the parents of and family members-- of these folks who were affected. That never goes away. And you understand that, you know, the way to vindicate the love and concern that these families have, is to make sure we've got a good policy, a smart policy, that prevents these kinds of things from happening in the future.

CHUCK TODD:

Assad essentially putting-- putting aside that priority that Assad must go, because ISIS is a more direct threat?

PRESIDENT OBAMA:

You know, the reason we're in this situation is because Assad brutalized his people and specifically brutalized the Sunni population that is the majority in Syria. It's going to be hard for us to attract Sunnis to fight against ISIL in this area if they think that we're doing it on behalf of Assad.

So, our attitude towards Assad continues to be that you know, through his actions, through using chemical weapons on his own people, dropping barrel bombs that killed innocent children that he-- he has foregone legitimacy. But when it comes to our policy and the coalition that we're putting together, our focus specifically is on ISIL. It's narrowly on ISIL.

We will continue to look for opportunities, even as we're going after terrorists who could harm Americans and our friends and partners in the region. We'll continue to look for opportunities to see if we can have any political resolution of the challenges in Syria.

We're going to need that. But in order to do that, we've got to have a moderate Sunni opposition. Right now in Syria, you've got a choice, in the minds of a lotta people, between radical Sunni extremists or Assad.

CHUCK TODD:

That's not a choice.

PRESIDENT OBAMA:

That's not a choice. We've got and what we know is is that there are millions of decent, good Sunnis, many of whom have been displaced. They're in Turkey. They're in Jordan. Many of them are still in Syria although getting squeezed between these two extremes. And we've got to be able to reach to them, find a military and political structure that'll allow them to express themselves. Then maybe we can get the kinda political resolution that we need.

The New York Times
7 Sep 2014

Destroying ISIS May Take Years, U.S. Officials Say

By ERIC SCHMITT, MICHAEL R. GORDON and HELENE COOPER

WASHINGTON — The Obama administration is preparing to carry out a campaign against the Islamic State in Iraq and Syria that may take three years to complete, requiring a sustained effort that could last until after President Obama has left office, according to senior administration officials.

The first phase, an air campaign with nearly 145 airstrikes in the past month, is already underway to protect ethnic and religious minorities and American diplomatic, intelligence and military personnel, and their facilities, as well as to begin rolling back ISIS gains in northern and western Iraq.

The next phase, which would begin sometime after Iraq forms a more inclusive government, scheduled this week, is expected to involve an intensified effort to train, advise or equip the Iraqi military, Kurdish fighters and possibly members of Sunni tribes.

The final, toughest and most politically controversial phase of the operation — destroying the terrorist army in its sanctuary inside Syria — might not be completed until the next administration. Indeed, some Pentagon planners envision a military campaign lasting at least 36 months.

Mr. Obama will use a speech to the nation on Wednesday to make his case for launching a United States-led offensive against Sunni militants gaining ground in the Middle East, seeking to rally support for a broad military mission while reassuring the public that he is not plunging American forces into another Iraq war.

“What I want people to understand,” Mr. Obama said in an interview with NBC’s “Meet the Press” that was broadcast Sunday, “is that over the course of months, we are going to be able to not just blunt the momentum” of the militants. “We are going to systematically degrade their capabilities; we’re going to shrink the territory that they control; and, ultimately, we’re going to defeat them,” he added.

The military campaign Mr. Obama is preparing has no obvious precedent. Unlike American counterterrorism operations in Yemen and Pakistan, it is not expected to be limited to drone strikes against militant leaders. Unlike the war in Afghanistan, it will not include the use of ground troops, which Mr. Obama has ruled out.

Unlike the Kosovo war that President Bill Clinton and NATO nations waged in 1999, it will not be compressed into an intensive 78-day tactical and strategic air campaign. And unlike during the air campaign that toppled the Libyan leader, Col. Muammar el-Qaddafi, in 2011, the Obama administration is no longer “leading from behind,” but plans to play the central role in building a coalition to counter ISIS.

“We have the ability to destroy ISIL,” Secretary of State John Kerry said last week at the NATO summit meeting in Wales, using an alternative name for the militant group. “It may take a year, it may take two years, it may take three years. But we’re determined it has to happen.”

Antony J. Blinken, Mr. Obama's deputy national security adviser, has suggested that the United States is undertaking a prolonged mission. "It's going to take time, and it will probably go beyond even this administration to get to the point of defeat," Mr. Blinken said last week on CNN.

Continue reading the main story Mr. Kerry is scheduled to head for the Middle East soon to solidify the anti-ISIS coalition. And Defense Secretary Chuck Hagel is traveling to Ankara, Turkey, on Monday to woo another potential ally in the fight against the Sunni militant group.

Although details of how the emerging coalition would counter ISIS remain undecided, several American officials said that they believe the list of allies so far includes Jordan, offering intelligence help, and Saudi Arabia, which has influence with Sunni tribes in Iraq and Syria and which has been funding moderate Syrian rebels.

The United Arab Emirates, officials said, has also indicated a willingness to consider airstrikes in Iraq. Germany has said it would send arms to pesh merga fighters in Kurdistan. And rising concern over foreign fighters returning home from Syria and Iraq may also have spurred Australia, Britain, Denmark and France to join the alliance.

Administration officials acknowledged, however, that getting those same countries to agree to airstrikes in Syria was proving harder. Continue reading the main story "Everybody is on board Iraq," an administration official said, speaking on condition of anonymity because the policy is still being developed. "But when it comes to Syria, there's more concern" about where airstrikes could lead. The official nonetheless expressed confidence that the countries would eventually come around to taking the fight into Syria, in part, he said, because "there's really no other alternative."

The talks between Mr. Hagel and the Turkish leadership may be crucial in determining whether the United States will be able to count on Ankara on a number of fronts, including closing the Turkish border to foreign fighters who have been using Turkey as a transit point from which to go to Syria and Iraq to join militant organizations and allowing the American military to carry out operations from bases in Turkey.

But Turkish officials have been wary of attracting notice from ISIS, given that the group holds the fate of 49 kidnapped Turkish diplomats in its hands. In June, Sunni militants with ISIS stormed the Turkish Consulate in Mosul, Iraq, kidnapping the consul general and other members of his staff, and their families, including three children.

Mr. Obama's planned speech suggests he may be moving closer to a decision on many remaining questions, including whether and at what point the White House might widen the air campaign to include targets across the border in Syria, possibly to include ISIS leadership and its equipment, supply depots and command centers. The time of the speech on Wednesday has not been announced.

Senior officials have repeatedly ruled out sending ground combat troops, a vow Mr. Obama reaffirmed in his appearance on "Meet the Press."

"This is not going to be an announcement about U.S. ground troops," he said. "This is not the equivalent of the Iraq war."

But it is not clear if that declaration would preclude the eventual deployment of small numbers of American Special Operations forces or C.I.A. operatives to call in airstrikes on

behalf of Kurdish fighters, Iraqi forces or Sunni tribes, a procedure that makes it much easier to distinguish between ISIS militants, civilians and counter ISIS fighters.

During the recent operation to retake the Mosul Dam, Kurdish soldiers, using a more roundabout procedure, provided the coordinates of ISIS fighters to the joint United States-Kurdish command center in Erbil, which in turn passed them to American aircraft, Masrour Barzani, the head of Kurdish intelligence, said in a recent interview.

The White House is counting on an effort by American, Iraqi and Gulf Arab officials to persuade Sunni tribesman in western Iraq, now aligned with ISIS, to break their ties after chafing under the harsh Shariah law the group has imposed.

Unless the new Iraqi government is substantially more inclusive, American encouragement and support for these groups to turn on ISIS may be far less effective than it was in 2007, when many tribes fought the forerunner of ISIS, Al Qaeda in Iraq.

Some Sunni tribal leaders are still bitter at the treatment under former Prime Minister Nuri Kamal al-Maliki, a Shiite.

"Even if they try we will not accept it," said Sheikh Ali Hatem Suleimani, a tribal leader in Anbar who lives in Erbil. "In the past, we fought against Al Qaeda and we cleaned the area of them. But the Americans gave control of Iraq to Maliki, who started to arrest, kill, and exile most of the tribal commanders who led the fight against Al Qaeda."

The New York Times
7 Sep 2014

Obama to Present Case for Broader U.S. Mission Against Militants

By JULIE HIRSCHFELD DAVIS

WASHINGTON — President Obama will use a speech to the nation on Wednesday to make his case for launching a United States-led offensive against Sunni militants gaining ground in the Middle East, seeking to rally support for a broad military mission while reassuring the public he is not plunging American forces into another Iraq war.

"I'm preparing the country to make sure that we deal with a threat from" the Islamic State in Iraq and Syria, or ISIS, Mr. Obama said in an interview broadcast Sunday on NBC's "Meet the Press."

"What I want people to understand," he said, "is that over the course of months, we are going to be able to not just blunt the momentum" of the militants. "We are going to systematically degrade their capabilities; we're going to shrink the territory that they control; and, ultimately, we're going to defeat them," he added.

The planned speech suggests that the president may be moving closer to a decision on whether to expand the month-old air campaign against ISIS in Iraq into Syria, and it is Mr. Obama's latest attempt to answer critics who charge that he lacks a viable plan or the fortitude to go after the group.

The president was adamant that he had no intention of sending American combat troops to go after ISIS, repeating no fewer than three times during the interview that he would not do so, and calling the idea of putting United States boots on the ground "a profound mistake."

"This is not going to be an announcement about U.S. ground troops," Mr. Obama said. "This is not the equivalent of the Iraq war."

The president's plans for a major address came just days after he returned from a NATO summit meeting in Wales, where he and top members of his administration worked on the sidelines to rally international support for a coalition to confront ISIS in Iraq and Syria. And the "Meet the Press" interview was broadcast hours after American warplanes carried out a new round of attacks on ISIS targets near a major hydroelectric dam in Iraq.

The speech is set for the day before the 13th anniversary of the Sept. 11, 2001, terrorist attacks, which touched off a broad military campaign to defeat the terrorist group Al Qaeda and, ultimately, to protracted American-led wars in Afghanistan and Iraq. Opposition to those wars and a vow to end them responsibly helped propel Mr. Obama to the White House.

The president said he planned to meet with congressional leaders on Tuesday to outline his strategy, but suggested he did not need a vote to move forward with his campaign against ISIS, saying he was "confident" that he has the authorization he needs. Still, Mr. Obama hinted that he might ask for more money for the mission, saying, "It's going to require some resources, I suspect, above what we are currently doing in the region."

Such a request would trigger a congressional debate and vote, and could hinder another of Mr. Obama's vows: to cut the Pentagon budget.

White House officials have said that Mr. Obama is operating under his constitutional powers as commander in chief in striking ISIS in Iraq, where the central government in Baghdad and Kurdish regional officials based in Erbil have requested United States assistance in battling the group. When the president announced what he described as a limited bombing campaign against ISIS, he said the goal was to protect Iraqi minorities besieged by ISIS and to safeguard American citizens and United States facilities in Iraq.

The president has been sending notifications to Congress on the airstrikes under the War Powers Act, which bars American troops from engaging in military action for more than 60 days without congressional authorization. But recent presidents have ignored that requirement. And some lawmakers in both parties are increasingly uncomfortable ceding the debate over military action in Iraq, and potentially Syria, to the president.

Senator Mitch McConnell, Republican of Kentucky and the minority leader, said Mr. Obama must explain to Congress how any additional authority he might seek to strike ISIS would protect Americans. He said training and equipping the militaries of partner nations to counter ISIS, as the president has done in Iraq and is proposing to do in Syria, "is not tenable and will not generate sufficient combat power to protect America."

If the president is prepared to engage Congress "with a strategic plan" to protect the United States and its allies from ISIS, Mr. McConnell said in a statement on Saturday, "I believe he will have significant congressional support." The ISIS threat, he added, "is real and it's growing. And it is time for President Obama to exercise some leadership in launching a response."

In the interview on Sunday, Mr. Obama said he envisioned the Free Syrian Army's providing the ground presence needed to confront ISIS in Syria. He said that until a moderate Sunni opposition emerged, there was no real hope of ousting President Bashar al-Assad of Syria. But the opposition has been fractured, and the moderate militias are viewed as far less capable than ISIS.

"Our attitude towards Assad continues to be that through his actions, through using chemical weapons on his own people, dropping barrel bombs that killed innocent children, that he has foregone legitimacy," Mr. Obama said. "But when it comes to our policy and the coalition that we're putting together, our focus specifically is on ISIL." (ISIL is the name used by administration officials for the militant group.)

It is a mark of how much things have changed since just one year ago, when Mr. Obama was weighing airstrikes to punish Mr. Assad for his use of chemical weapons. Faced with a new array of international crises in recent months, the president said he was "energized" by the challenges facing him. But he also showed signs of strain during the interview, admitting that the demands of his position — including dealing with Russia's intervention in Ukraine, the rise of ISIS and to the Ebola outbreak in West Africa — were taking a toll.

"There are days where I'm not getting enough sleep, because we've got a lot on our plate," he said.

Mr. Obama also suggested that he regretted his decision last month to go golfing immediately after responding publicly to the ISIS release of a video showing the beheading of the American journalist James Foley.

"I should've anticipated the optics," the president said, adding that the "theater" of his job was "not something that always comes naturally to me."

"But it matters. And I'm mindful of that."

It is one of the pitfalls of any presidential vacation, Mr. Obama said in the interview. "What I'd love," the president added, "is a vacation from the press."

AP
8 Sep 2014

Obama to outline strategy on Islamic State Wednesday

BY TOM RAUM

WASHINGTON (AP) -- President Barack Obama plans to begin laying out his strategy for defeating Islamic State militants expanding their grip in Iraq and Syria.

He'll outline his evolving tactics when he meets with congressional leaders from both parties at the White House on Tuesday and then delivers a speech Wednesday on the eve of the 13th anniversary of the Sept. 11, 2001, terror attacks.

Lawmakers said in advance that they would like the president to give specifics.

The president should target command and control centers and oil refineries controlled by insurgents within Syria, suggested Sen. Marco Rubio, R-Fla., who sits on both the Senate Intelligence and Foreign Relations Committees.

Rubio, claiming that Obama has committed "presidential malpractice in his foreign policy," said he is eager to hear directly what Obama "should have said months, weeks ago."

"First, clearly explain to the American people what our national security interests are in the region" and spell out the risk that Islamic State militants pose "for us, short-term and long-term, and why they matter," Rubio said on CBS' "Face the Nation."

"Clearly, he's put together a coalition of the willing - we have heard that before - to tackle this problem," said House Intelligence Committee Chairman Mike Rogers, R-Mich. "That's good."

"And then I think he needs to engage Congress, the American people, on what exactly we're going to do here," Rogers told CNN.

Sen. Dianne Feinstein, a California Democrat who heads the Senate Intelligence Committee, said on the same CNN program that Obama needs to spell out both the diplomatic and military components of his strategy.

"Time's a-wasting, because we have now said that we're going to go on the offensive. And it's time for America to project power and strength," Feinstein said.

Obama sparked criticism, most of it from Republicans, for his remark last week that "we don't have a strategy yet" for confronting Islamic extremists gaining both land and followers in the Middle East.

His upcoming sessions with lawmakers and the speech to the nation are clearly an attempt to try to show he now has an evolving strategy in place.

"The next phase is now to start going on some offense," Obama said in an interview with NBC's "Meet the Press."

"But this is not going to be an announcement about U.S. ground troops," he added in the session taped Saturday and broadcast Sunday. The operations will be "similar to the kinds of counterterrorism campaigns" the U.S. has waged in the past, Obama said. "In Syria, the boots on the ground have to be Syrian."

"I just want the American people to understand the nature of the threat and how we're going to deal with it and to have confidence that we'll be able to deal with it," Obama said in the NBC interview that followed his return from a NATO summit in Wales where the Islamic State threat was a major topic.

At that gathering, the U.S. and nine allies agreed to take on the militants because of the threat they pose to member countries.

Meanwhile, former Republican presidential candidate Mitt Romney suggested Obama has been indecisive in dealing with the crisis in Syria as well as other foreign-policy challenges. "I think the president is really out of touch with reality when it comes to what's happening in the world," Romney said on Fox News. "He is so out of touch with reality that he hasn't taken the action necessary to prevent very bad things from happening."

In addition to laying claim to territory, the militants have targeted religious and ethnic minority groups and threatened U.S. personnel and interests in the region.

At Obama's direction, the U.S. military has conducted more than 130 airstrikes against Islamic State militants in Iraq in the past month. In retaliation, the group recently beheaded two American journalists it had been holding hostage in Syria, where the organization also operates.

But the president has repeated his opposition to sending in U.S. ground troops to engage in direct combat with the militants, who have laid claim to large swaths of territory in Iraq and Syria. Lawmakers have pressed Obama, so far unsuccessfully, to expand the airstrikes further.

AP
8 Sep 2014

Obama to Outline Strategy to Defeat Islamic State

WASHINGTON — President Barack Obama will outline plans this week for an expanded U.S. campaign to defeat violent Islamic State militants in Iraq and Syria, a strategy that will also involve cooperation from allies in Europe, the Middle East and elsewhere.

Obama will launch an aggressive effort to build support for his strategy on Capitol Hill and with the American public. He'll meet with congressional leaders from both parties at the White House Tuesday, then deliver a speech detailing his strategy on Wednesday.

The president's address will come on the eve of the 13th anniversary of the Sept. 11, 2001 terror attacks. While U.S. officials say they do not believe the Islamic State currently has the capacity to carry out that type of attack, the Obama administration sees an urgent need to stop the militants from gaining that ability.

Officials say Obama's strategy will include military, political and diplomatic efforts.

The U.S. is already launching airstrikes against Islamic State targets in Iraq and Obama has been considering expanding that effort into Syria, where the militants have a safe haven. The president is also pressing Iraq's government to fulfill pledges to form a more inclusive government. And he wants Arab nations, particularly Sunni-majority states, to join the West in efforts to confront the Islamic State.

But Obama has ruled out putting U.S. military personnel on the ground in either Iraq or Syria in a combat role. Officials say he instead sees U.S. air power as a way to give cover to Iraqi forces and possibly Western-backed rebels in Syria and help them take on the militants.

"This is not going to be an announcement about U.S. ground troops," he said in a weekend interview with NBC's "Meet The Press." He added that the operations will be "similar to the kinds of counterterrorism campaigns" the U.S. has waged in the past.

House Intelligence Committee Chairman Mike Rogers, R-Mich., welcomed Obama's efforts to form an international coalition to join the U.S. in such efforts. He also said Obama needed to engage with lawmakers and the public.

"I think in Congress we need to expose all members to the level of threat that those of us on the national security committees see every day," Rogers said on MSNBC. He added that Washington political leaders should not give the Islamic militants the "time and space" to grow into a more formidable force, which he said happened with the al-Qaida terrorist network.

While Obama has promised to coordinate with Congress, he has not said definitively whether he will seek congressional authorization for any military action he will take. He did not seek authorization for lawmakers for the airstrikes the U.S. is currently launching inside Iraq.

The president did formally notify Congress Monday that the U.S. opened a new front in the airstrike campaign over the weekend, hitting targets around the Haditha Dam.

The airstrike campaign began before the Islamic State group announced that it had beheaded two American journalists in Syria. The murders of James Foley and Steven Sotloff sparked outrage in the U.S. and around the world and added new urgency to discussions over how to go after the militants.

In addition to laying claim to territory, the militants have targeted religious and ethnic minority groups and threatened U.S. personnel and interests in the region. And U.S. and European officials fear that an influx of foreign fighters who have joined the militants could ultimately return to their home countries and launch attacks there.

Obama sparked criticism, most of it from Republicans, for his remark last week that "we don't have a strategy yet" for confronting the extremists.

His upcoming sessions with lawmakers and the speech to the nation are clearly an attempt to try to show he now has an evolving strategy in place.

"The next phase is now to start going on some offense," Obama said in the NBC interview.

Former Republican presidential candidate Mitt Romney suggested Obama has been indecisive in dealing with the crisis in Syria as well as other foreign-policy challenges.

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The Wall Street Journal

8 Sep 2014

Islamic State Helps Reshape Obama's Second Term

Instead of Focusing on Expansive Domestic Agenda, President Is Being Drawn Back to Mideast Conflicts

When President Barack Obama speaks to the nation on Wednesday, he won't merely be discussing his strategy for taking on the militant fighters of the Islamic State. He will be acknowledging, tacitly, that he is overseeing a second term radically different from the one he imagined.

In that sense, Mr. Obama has become only the latest American president to learn that history doesn't afford the occupant of the Oval Office the luxury of choosing what kind of presidency he gets to conduct. A president has many powers, but the power to fully control the tides of history as they form around him isn't one of them. Like the rest of us, he often is left to respond to them.

This appears to be a painful truth for Mr. Obama, which helps explain why he has been so obviously reluctant—and so dangerously slow, his critics say—to embrace the challenge of confronting the resurgence of radical Islamic forces in Iraq and the dangerous cauldron of instability brewing next door in Syria. The second Obama term was to be about escaping the morass of war and terror emanating from the Muslim world in order to move on to other needs back home; it wasn't to be about being sucked back into that morass.

To grasp the disconnect, it's worth stepping back to consider the broader arc of the Obama presidency. From the president's viewpoint, his first term was largely consumed in dealing with the aftermath of giant problems not of his making: the financial collapse of 2008 and the long wars in Iraq and Afghanistan.

That left enough political bandwidth to undertake only one other big domestic initiative, which was health-care reform. That task turned out to be so politically fraught that it helped cost Democrats control of the House in 2010—a setback that in turn made it all the harder to move beyond war and economic debates and on to other issues.

The second Obama term, though, was to be the time when those legacy problems were swept away and the path cleared for what Mr. Obama really wanted to pursue, which was a new Democratic domestic agenda. To see that agenda—and to sense how far the second term has drifted away from it—look back at the inaugural address Mr. Obama delivered upon taking the oath of office for the second time in 2013.

"A decade of war is now ending," Mr. Obama declared from the Capitol's steps. He then moved on to a litany of domestic goals and aspirations that amounted to a Democratic clarion call for activist government in the second term. The list included attacking income inequality, reforming the tax code and the education system, improving job-training programs, tackling climate change and increasing use of renewable energy.

Meantime, he said, Americans "still believe that enduring security and lasting peace do not require perpetual war." As recently as this May, in a speech at West Point, Mr. Obama underscored that point, declaring that "U.S. military action cannot be the only—or even primary—component of our leadership in every instance."

Twenty months after his inaugural address, there has been little progress on that domestic agenda. And now Mr. Obama is straining to prevent the perception, at least, that perpetual war is returning.

In some ways, this merely places Mr. Obama in the long line of American leaders forced to rethink their presidencies midstream. Franklin Roosevelt was the New Deal president before the rise of fascism turned him into the World War II president.

Lyndon Johnson was on his way to being the Great Society president when the Vietnam War grew in to a monster that overwhelmed, and in many ways destroyed, his presidency. George W. Bush entered office intending to become a new kind of compassionate conservative on the home front. Eight months into office, the 9/11 terror attacks transformed his presidency into one swamped by a war on terror almost no one saw coming.

So what will Mr. Obama tell the nation? He is likely to make two large points. The first is that he has concluded that the fight to stop Islamic State may take not just the time left in his presidency but perhaps years beyond that to execute. The U.S., in short, hasn't left behind the long struggle after all.

Second, he will say this fight will be different from the ones his predecessor launched in Iraq and Afghanistan. The soldiers on the front line this time, he will say, will have to be the very Sunni Arabs threatened by Islamic State's rise, not American troops sent to save them from it. That, he will imply, is the smart, not the stupid, way to take on the challenge.

Through it all, it is hard to avoid the perception that Mr. Obama is straining to craft a presidency on his terms, not the terms the rest of the world sets for him. As his predecessors have discovered, though, that often isn't how things work at 1600 Pennsylvania Avenue.

The Wall Street Journal
7 Sep 2014

Obama to Spell Out Strategy to Defeat Islamic State

President's Wednesday Speech to Outline Plan to Beat Back Militants in Iraq and Syria

By PATRICK O'CONNOR, DION NISSENBAUM and CAROL E. LEE

WASHINGTON—President Barack Obama will lay out plans this week for expanding the U.S. military campaign against the extremist group Islamic State, including the possibility of airstrikes on the militants in their Syrian strongholds, U.S. officials said.

His appeal for support to a divided Congress and a doubtful American public comes as the U.S. military is broadening its month-old campaign of air attacks against the Sunni fighters in Iraq. An intense barrage of American airstrikes on Sunday hit militants trying to seize control of the strategic Haditha Dam in Iraq's Sunni heartland northwest of Baghdad.

In meetings with members of Congress on Tuesday and a speech to the country on Wednesday, the president plans to spell out action he says is designed to "degrade and ultimately destroy" the group that has captured large tracts of territory in Iraq and Syria.

The additional American steps could include airstrikes on the group's bases in Syria, U.S. officials say. But Mr. Obama again this weekend emphatically ruled out sending additional U.S. combat troops to the region, although he has sent nearly 1,000 troops to protect American facilities and advise Iraqi forces.

Mr. Obama has described the upcoming mission as a lengthy campaign that will take place in phases, suggesting a long-term U.S. commitment in the region.

The president is expected to press Congress to quickly authorize his proposal last spring for an additional \$500 million to arm and train pro-Western rebels in Syria. He will also detail his plan for a still-emerging international coalition that he wants to include allies in Europe and the Middle East.

"We are going to systematically degrade their capabilities," Mr. Obama said in an interview with NBC's "Meet the Press" in which he outlined the coming White House push. "We're going to shrink the territory that they control. And ultimately we're going to defeat them," he said in the interview taped Saturday and aired Sunday.

Mr. Obama's push came as the U.S. military opened a new front in its air campaign by targeting fighters near Haditha Dam, marking the first time American forces have hit Anbar Province, the epicenter of the Sunni insurgency after the 2003 invasion.

The attacks hit a command post, armored vehicles and other targets, including two anti-aircraft artillery pieces—the most intensive set of strikes since Mr. Obama authorized the bombing campaign.

U.S. Defense Secretary Chuck Hagel said the strikes against the group, also known as ISIL or ISIS, came at the request of the Iraqi government and were in line with the limited objectives of the current U.S. military mission in Iraq to protect infrastructure in the

country.

"If that dam were to fall into ISIL's hands, or if the dam were to be destroyed, the damage that that would cause would be very significant," Mr. Hagel said Sunday during a joint news conference in Tbilisi, Georgia, after urging his Georgian counterpart to join the effort to fight the group.

The flurry of action is the latest in an evolving administration response since Islamist extremists surged across Iraq earlier this year.

Mr. Obama's address on Wednesday comes at a symbolic moment, on the eve of the 13th anniversary of the Sept. 11 terror attacks and as the country is grappling with the beheadings of two Americans by Islamic State.

Facing growing pressure from lawmakers to articulate a strategy for a military campaign he began a month ago, the president plans for the first time to offer details about his strategy.

The White House has come under repeated fire from Republicans and Democrats alike for sending mixed signals about Mr. Obama's goals in confronting Islamic militants.

Over the weekend, Senate Minority Leader Mitch McConnell expressed openness to a dialogue with Mr. Obama about the issue. The Kentucky Republican also called for the destruction of ISIS in Iraq and Syria.

In the NBC interview, the president pledged to "hunt down" Islamic State members wherever they are, referring explicitly to Iraq and Syria.

By committing to a greater military and diplomatic involvement, Mr. Obama is testing the appetite of an American public that has become wary of foreign engagements. The president said his speech would address some of those concerns.

"I just want the American people to understand the nature of the threat and how we're going to deal with it," Mr. Obama told NBC.

While U.S. warplanes and drones have conducted more than 140 strikes in Iraq, U.S. officials say that targeting Islamic State within Syria is more complicated. The group is one of many fighting in a multi-sided civil war with the regime of Bashar al-Assad and moderate, Western-backed rebels who oppose both the regime and Islamic State.

In Iraq, the U.S. is relying on Kurdish and Iraqi military forces to fight extremists on the ground, but has few viable fighters in Syria to take on the same job.

However, the president said that, like in Iraq, "the boots on the ground have to be Syrian," naming the moderate Syrian rebels who would gain from the \$500 million the administration proposed to spend last spring.

The local fighters would be backed by a global alliance, to provide a range of assistance, including humanitarian aid and weapons. The U.K. and Australia, where leaders are especially concerned about the risk of foreign fighters returning to carry out attacks in their home countries, could join the U.S. in launching airstrikes in both Iraq and Syria, officials have said.

Other countries, including Germany, Albania and Italy, are stepping in to provide weapons

and ammunition to Kurdish fighters already engaged with Islamic State—a critical component Mr. Obama needs to fulfill his pledge not to send American troops back into combat in Iraq.

The president and his national-security team want to ensure allies in the region, such as Saudi Arabia and Jordan, play a role to ensure the alliance is not seen as a West versus East confrontation. American officials also hope Turkey, which borders Syria, will play a pivotal role.

The president said he hasn't seen any "immediate intelligence" to suggest Islamic State could carry out a terrorist attack on U.S. soil. But he said one of the goals of any military intervention would be to prevent that possibility.

The president has made it clear since the airstrikes began that he has no plans to send U.S. troops to the region, relying instead of allies to do much of the fighting. He argued that it makes no sense for the American military to "serially occupy" countries throughout the Middle East.

The forthcoming debate promises to test public attitudes on such questions. A Wall Street Journal/NBC News poll conducted in April found almost half of those surveyed wanted to see the U.S. be less active on the world stage— more than twice as many who wanted the U.S. to be more involved. And the president continues to suffer the worst approval ratings of his tenure in the White House for his handling of foreign policy.

While Mr. Obama is expected to ask Congress for support, he is not likely to predicate his plans on formal backing from lawmakers.

"I am going to be asking Congress to make sure that they understand and support what our plan is," Mr. Obama said in the NBC interview.

The New York Times
5 Sep 2014

Obama Enlists 9 Allies to Help in the Battle Against ISIS

By HELENE COOPER

NEWPORT, Wales — President Obama escalated the American response to the marauding Islamic State in Iraq and Syria on Friday, recruiting at least nine allies to help crush the organization and offering the outlines of a coordinated military strategy that echoes the war on terror developed by his predecessor, George W. Bush, more than a decade ago.

In his most expansive comments to date about how the United States and its friends could defeat ISIS, a once-obscure group of Sunni militants that has now upended the Middle East and overshadowed Al Qaeda, Mr. Obama said the effort would rely on American airstrikes against its leaders and positions, strengthen the moderate Syrian rebel groups to reclaim ground lost to ISIS, and enlist friendly governments in the region to join the fight.

While the president's aides maintained that he has not yet decided to authorize airstrikes in Syria — which he has already done on a limited basis in Iraq — Mr. Obama likened his developing strategy on ISIS to the American effort against Al Qaeda in Pakistan's tribal regions, which has relied heavily on airstrikes.

The president commented on the battle against the Islamic State during a news conference at the NATO summit in Wales.

Mr. Obama has been under enormous pressure to articulate a way to counter ISIS, which has proclaimed itself an Islamic caliphate that knows no borders and has demonstrated ruthless behavior, including the videotaped beheadings of two Americans. After creating a political tempest by saying last week that his administration lacked a strategy, Mr. Obama sought on Friday to portray himself as spearheading the effort.

But in so doing, the president risks further entangling the American military in exactly the type of costly foreign conflict he has long sought to escape. And his administration has been unable to explain how he can vanquish ISIS without indirectly aiding President Bashar al-Assad of Syria, regarded by the administration as an odious leader who must resign.

Nonetheless, Mr. Obama's comments, made at the conclusion of a NATO summit meeting here, were in effect a significant expansion of his earlier assessments of the ISIS threat — simply by offering a direct comparison to the strategy against Qaeda militants.

"You initially push them back, you systematically degrade their capabilities, you narrow their scope of action, you slowly shrink the space, the territory that they may control, you take out their leadership," Mr. Obama said at a news conference here. "And over time, they are not able to conduct the same kinds of terrorist attacks as they once could."

He said that "we are going to degrade and ultimately defeat ISIL, the same way that we have gone after Al Qaeda," using an alternate acronym for ISIS. He drew the analogy to Pakistan as an example of how the United States can go to war against militants while limiting the number of American ground combat troops.

Mr. Obama spoke after aides had unveiled what Defense Secretary Chuck Hagel called the "core coalition" to fight the ISIS militants, the outcome of a hastily organized meeting on the sidelines of the NATO summit talks. Diplomats and defense officials from the United States, Britain, France, Australia, Canada, Germany, Turkey, Italy, Poland and Denmark huddled to devise a two-pronged strategy: strengthening allies on the ground in Iraq and Syria, while bombing Sunni militants from the air.

"There is no containment policy for ISIL," Secretary of State John Kerry said at the start of the meeting. "They're an ambitious, avowed, genocidal, territorial-grabbing, caliphate-desiring quasi state with an irregular army, and leaving them in some capacity intact anywhere would leave a cancer in place that will ultimately come back to haunt us."

But he and other officials made clear that at the moment, any ground combat troops would come from either Iraqi security forces and Kurdish pesh merga fighters in Iraq, or the moderate Syrian rebels opposed to President Assad in Syria. "Obviously I think that's a red line for everybody here: no boots on the ground," Mr. Kerry said.

For Mr. Obama, assembling a coalition to fight ISIS is particularly important to a president whose initial arrival on the global stage was centered around his opposition to the war in Iraq. He is loath to be viewed as going it alone now that he has been dragged back into a combat role in the same country.

"Getting sucked deeply back into another set of violent conflicts in the Middle East runs against the grain and the very DNA of this administration," said Brian Katulis, a national security expert with the Center for American Progress, a research organization with close ties to the Obama administration. "But the stunning actions by ISIS this summer has been a wake-up call."

Even as Mr. Obama is weighing airstrikes in Syria, he and his aides have been questioning what to do afterward, especially since targeting ISIS in Syria will help Mr. Assad.

An administration official said the reasons for assembling a coalition went beyond any political cover that such an alliance might provide with a war-weary American public. For one thing, the official said, certain countries bring expertise, like Britain and Australia in special operations, Jordan in intelligence and Saudi Arabia in financing.

American officials are hoping to expand the coalition to many countries, particularly in the region. Obama administration officials said privately that in addition to the participants at the meeting Friday, the United States was hoping to get quiet intelligence help about the Sunni militants from Jordan. Its leader, King Abdullah II, was attending the Wales summit meeting.

United States officials said they also expected Saudi Arabia to contribute to funding moderate Syrian rebel groups. In addition, Yousef Al Otaiba, the United Arab Emirates ambassador to the United States, said in a statement this week that the Emirates stood ready to join the fight against ISIS. "No one has more at stake than the U.A.E. and other moderate countries in the region that have rejected the regressive Islamist creed and embraced a different, forward-looking path," the ambassador said.

Enlisting support from Sunni populations in Syria and Iraq is crucial, experts said, because airstrikes alone will not suffice.

Matthew G. Olsen, director of the National Counterterrorism Center in Washington, sought to define more clearly what destroying ISIS would actually mean on the ground.

"From a counterterrorism standpoint, understand that it doesn't mean eradicating every single person aligned with the group," Mr. Olsen said. "We need to be realistic about that."

And like the comprehensive strategy to combat Al Qaeda that has taken years to develop and carry out, Mr. Olsen and other counterterrorism officials said on Friday that destroying the threat from ISIS could take a long time. Even if successful, they said, such a strategy would require maintaining pressure on any remnants of the group.

Administration officials said support for moderate rebels in Syria is critical. This summer, President Obama set aside \$500 million to train and support vetted members of the moderate opposition to Mr. Assad. Officials say they expect Congress to approve that request next month.

But even after that money is approved, American officials will face obstacles in strengthening the Free Syrian Army, the moderates of choice for the United States. "This is going to take months," one Defense Department official said on Friday.
